November 18, 2025

To: The Sherwood Foundation
808 Conagra Drive Ste. 200
Omaha, NE 68102

From: Jennifer J. Tostlebe, PhD
Assistant Professor
School of Criminology and Criminal Justice
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Final Report – Improving the Prospects of Formerly Incarcerated Adults

Dear Sherwood Foundation,

I am pleased to share this final report for "Improving the prospects of formerly incarcerated adults." This initiative was supported from January to July 2025, with a no-cost extension until November 2025, to develop core processes, procedures, and documentation for a reentry program serving individuals returning from incarceration.

Project Overview

At the end of 2022, nearly 1.1 million people were incarcerated in state and federal prisons, and about 600,000 individuals were released that year.[1] More than 95 percent of incarcerated individuals will be released at some point in the future,[2] yet the reentry process remains fraught with challenges.[3,4] The most representative studies reveal that approximately 80% are rearrested within nine years,[5] and slightly over half return to prison on a technical parole violation or with a new conviction within five years.[6]

Successful reentry depends on stable housing, quality employment, community support, drug and mental health treatment, and identity change.[7–11] Many individuals face significant barriers in obtaining these essentials. These challenges have has led to the development of government and nonprofit programs that provide structured reentry support.

The original project began in January 2025 with the goal of documenting and strengthening the 50th Street Landing Reentry Program in Omaha, Nebraska. Founded in 2022 by Tom Hightower and Shane Reilly, 50th Street Landing offered a 12-week residential program focused on life skills, recovery, prosocial activities, and community service.

Our Stage One objectives were to:

- Establish a screening process with eligibility/ineligibility criteria;
- Document the program's structure, goals, and requirements in a standardized format;
- Define and track program completion criteria and collect descriptive participant outcomes;
- Create a brochure for outreach and awareness; and
- Deliver presentations to criminal justice system leaders.

Program Transition

In March 2025, an organizational change required the grant to shift focus from 50th Street Landing to Never Give Up Transitional Living (NGU), a new reentry program led by Shane Reilly. While the program name, house, and certain operational details changed, the core mission—improving the reentry prospectus of formerly incarcerated adults—remained the same. The grant's focus on developing foundational processes, documentation, and outreach materials continued with minimal interruption owing to Mr. Reilly's steadfast determination to get the new program up-and-running.

Key Deliverables

Between January and November 2025, the following resources were created or finalized for NGU:

1. Never Give Up Program Description *(Appendix A)*
2. Application Form *(Appendix B)*
3. Phone Screening Interview Guide *(Appendix C)*
4. Rules and Expectations Document *(Appendix D)*
5. Employee Role Descriptions *(Appendix E)*
6. Program Orientation Form (for case manager use; *Appendix F*)
7. Participant Tracking Excel Sheet *(template; Appendix G)*
    a. Since March 2025, 48 men have been admitted to the NGU program.
    b. As of November 18, 2025, 56.2% of eligible participants graduated on time (18/32), 40.4% of all participants graduated early (19/47), 43.7% of eligible participants were removed due to program noncompliance (14/32). One additional participant left the program early – in good standing – after achieving maximum benefits.
8. DBT Programming Guide and Worksheets *(Appendix H)*
9. Program Flyer *(Appendix I)*
10. Website (https://www.nevergiveupomaha.org)
11. Program Brochure *(Appendix J)*
12. Presentation during the NGU Fundraiser event on November 4, 2025 (*Appendix K*)
13. Additional accomplishment: My PhD student and I submitted a co-authored book chapter with Shane Reilly, further enhancing the program's visibility (*Appendix L*).

Impact

The creation of these resources has provided Never Give Up Transitional Living with:

- A standardized intake and eligibility process to guide referrals
- Clear participant expectations, rules, and orientation procedures
- Structured tools for tracking participant progress and outcomes
- Evidence-based programming materials (DBT guide) ready for implementation
- Professional outreach tools (website, flyer, brochure) to connect with partners and funders
- Defined staff roles for more efficient service delivery

These deliverables form the backbone of a sustainable reentry program model and position the organization for future expansion and evaluation.

Next Steps

Looking ahead to Stage Two, I have met with Program Director, Shane Reilly, and Executive Director, Julie Micek, to discuss and determine the most feasible formal evaluation design. We have agreed to move forward with a randomized controlled trial evaluation design. I am in the process of drafting a grant proposal, including methods, research questions, and hypotheses, which I intend to submit to foundation RFPs. This project will be pre-registered prior to implementation to ensure transparency and rigor in our evaluation process.

In addition, my doctoral student (Taylor Gonzales) is interested in completing her dissertation on this program, which will include a process evaluation alongside the formal outcome evaluation. This presents an opportunity to not only measure program effectiveness but also gain deeper insight into how the program operates and the mechanisms driving participant success. Key leadership at NGU have given the green light for this dissertation.

Thank you to The Sherwood Foundation for making this work possible. Your investment has enabled the development of a robust operational framework to better serve individuals returning from incarceration and to strengthen their changes for successful reintegration.

Sincerely,



Jennifer J. Tostlebe, PhD
School of Criminology and Criminal Justice
University of Nebraska Omaha

Table 1. Objectives vs. Deliverables

	Stage One Objectives				
	Screening Process	**Structure, Goals, and Requirements**	**Completion Criteria and Outcomes**	**Brochure**	**Presentations**
Stage One Deliverables	Application Form	Never Give Up Program Description	Never Give Up Program Description	Program Flyer	NGU Fundraiser (11/4/25)
	Phone Screening Interview Guide	Rules and Expectations Document	Program Orientation Form	Website	
		Employee Role Descriptions	Participant Tracking Excel Sheet	Brochure	
		DBT Programming Guide and Worksheets	Website		

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Appendix A. NGU Program Description

Never Give Up Transitional Living Program Description

Updated: May 14, 2025

1. Program Overview

a. Program Name: Never Give Up Transitional Living
b. Organization: Good Turn Labor LLC
c. Contact Person: Shane Reilly, MS
d. Contact Phone and Email: 402.359.7404 / ngutlomaha@gmail.com

2. Establishing the Problem: Situation Statement

The average daily population of the Nebraska Department of Correctional Services (NDCS) is approximately 5,880 individuals, and roughly 2,000 people are released from Nebraska prisons each year. Nationally, over 95 percent of currently incarcerated individuals will be released at some point in the future. The reentry process presents serious challenges to the reintegration of formerly incarcerated persons in the community, with the most representative studies revealing that approximately 80% are rearrested within nine years, and slightly over half return to prison on a technical parole violation or with a new conviction within five years.

Critical to a successful reentry experience are obtaining quality employment, securing a prosocial place to live, developing a community support network, getting drug treatment (as needed), and changing one's identity and negative thinking patterns. However, many formerly incarcerated individuals have difficulties obtaining and maintaining these critical elements.

3. Introduction

The Never Give Up (NGU) Transitional Living Program is a structured transitional housing program operated under the nonprofit 501(c)(3) organization, Good Turn Labor, to support formerly incarcerated individuals as they reintegrate into the community. The program provides safe, stable housing alongside employment support, dialectical behavior therapy (DBT), Intensive Outpatient Programming (IOP) for mental health and substance use treatment, life skills training, social support, and more to reduce recidivism and improve long-term outcomes.

Designed to align with the priorities of the NDCS, Nebraska Board of Parole, and Nebraska Department of Parole Supervision services, NGU is a sober, transitional, peer-support intervention program that ensures returning citizens have the resources and structure necessary to successfully transition from incarceration to independent living.

4. Program Goals and Objectives

Program Goal: To support individuals transitioning from NDCS to the community by providing a peer-led, structured, and stable living reentry program. The NGU program's overarching goal is to reduce recidivism and promote successful reintegration by fostering personal accountability, community support, and access to essential resources.

Program Objectives: Guided by a peer-driven approach, the NGU Transitional Living program creates a supportive space where individuals with lived experiences (i.e., previously incarcerated) serve as mentors, helping participants navigate challenges related to addiction, antisocial thinking patterns, employment, and prosocial and community reintegration. By offering structured support, the program seeks to empower participants to rebuild their lives and achieve long-term stability.

These goals align with the NGU Transitional Living program's logic model (Figure 1), which outlines the key inputs, activities and outputs, and outcomes of the program.

More specifically:

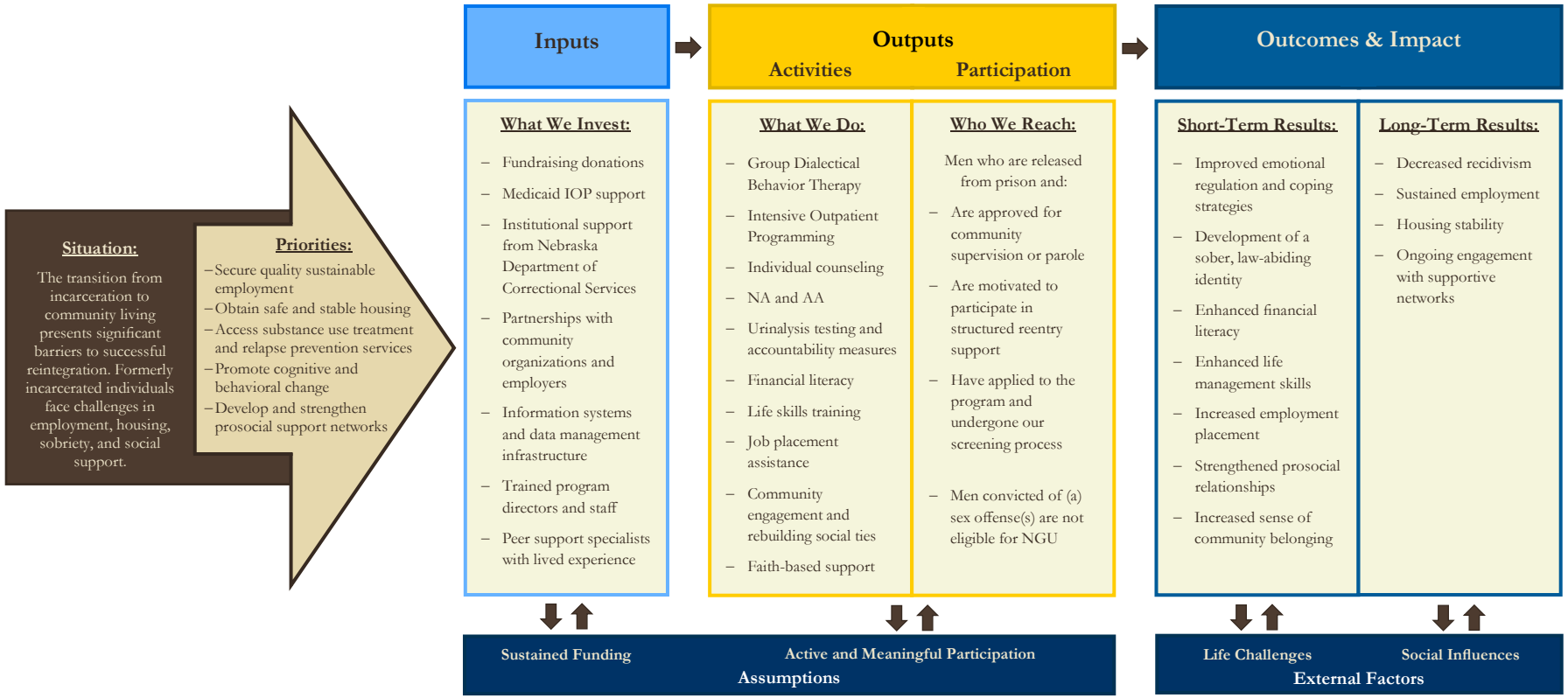
- **Inputs:** Program investments include sustained donation and financial support, buy-in from NDCS and the Nebraska Board of Parole, and strong partnerships with community organizations. Additionally, the program requires a contracted grant writer, external accounting firm, and reliable information system and data management tools to track progress and outcomes. Further, a dedicated staff team—including a team of directors, a case manager, a resident manager, peer support specialists, and a health support and counseling specialist—plays a crucial role in supporting participants.
- **Outputs/Activities:** The program provides a comprehensive range of services to support the successful reintegration of formerly incarcerated individuals. It includes group counseling using dialectical behavior therapy (DBT); Intensive Outpatient Program (IOP) grounded in cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT), motivational interviewing (MI), and the 12-Step approach for mental health and substance use treatment; and access to narcotics anonymous (NA) and alcoholics anonymous (AA) meetings to address underlying issues. Participants receive financial literacy and life skills training. Individual counseling is available as needed. Employment assistance is offered to all participants, as well as fun opportunities for social development. The program also encourages engagement with faith-based communities and ensures accountability through regular urinalysis screenings.
- **Short-term Outcomes:** As a result of dialectical behavior therapy (DBT) in group counseling, individuals develop emotional regulation skills, improve decision-making, and gain a deeper understanding of their thoughts and behaviors. Biweekly Intensive Outpatient Programming (IOP) is geared toward stabilizing participants' symptoms

(mental health, substance use, or both), developing coping skills, supporting ongoing recovery, and prevent substance abuse relapse. Attending narcotics anonymous (NA) and alcoholics anonymous (AA) meetings encourages individuals to identify as addicts, recognize the impact of substance use on their lives, and commit to a recovery-focused lifestyle. Through financial literacy education, participants gain a basic understanding of personal finances, enabling them to make more informed financial decisions and manage their money effectively. Life skills training equips them with practical abilities such as using transportation, accessing phone services, obtaining identification, and navigating Medicaid and SNAP benefits, increasing their independence and ability to function in daily life. Individual counseling provides personalized support, helping participants engage in self-reflection, address personal challenges, and develop healthier coping mechanisms. Employment assistance enables individuals to secure and maintain stable jobs, fostering financial independence and long-term success in the workforce. Social development activities and efforts to rebuild social ties allow participants to establish meaningful relationships and feel like a valued part of society. Engagement with faith-based communities provides additional emotional and social support, fostering a sense of belonging and connection to the larger society. Lastly, regular urinalysis screenings hold individuals accountable for maintaining sobriety, reinforcing their commitment to a drug- and alcohol-free lifestyle.

- **Long-term Outcomes:** The program aims to create lasting positive changes in the lives of formerly incarcerated individuals by reducing recidivism and supporting their successful reintegration into society. By obtaining stable, quality employment, participants gain financial independence and a sense of purpose. Securing a prosocial place to live provides stability and a safe environment that encourages personal growth. Developing a strong community support network helps individuals build meaningful relationships and maintain accountability in their recovery and reintegration journey. Accessing and completing drug treatment enables participants to maintain sobriety and improve their overall well-being. Ultimately, by changing negative thinking patterns and adopting a new, prosocial identity, individuals are empowered to break the cycle of incarceration and lead fulfilling, productive lives as engaged members of their communities.

This framework ensures that the program remains outcome-driven, measuring success through both short-term achievements (e.g., securing stable employment, rebuilding social ties, and obtaining financial literacy, etc.) and long-term impacts (e.g., reduced recidivism).

Figure 1. Never Give Up Transitional Living program: Logical model for successful community reintegration



Note. Recidivism is defined as returning to prison within three years post-release
Abbreviations: IOP = Intensive Outpatient Program, NA = Narcotics Anonymous, AA = Alcoholics Anonymous, NGU = Never Give Up Transitional Living

5. Target Population

The Never Give Up Transitional Living program serves men released from prison who:

- Are approved for community supervision or parole
- Are motivated to participate in structured reentry support
- Have applied to the program and completed a phone interview and background review

Men convicted of (a) sex offense(s) are not eligible for the NGU program. This exclusion is based on several important considerations:

- Specialized Needs: Individuals with sex offense convictions typically require more intensive and specialized reentry programming that extends beyond the scope of this housing model.
- Client Safety Considerations: The shared housing environment and support services offered in this program are not designed to accommodate the unique supervision, treatment, and safety requirements for individuals with sex offense convictions/histories. In a setting where peer mentorship and community support are key, individuals with sex offenses can pose safety risks to others and vice versa, as they dynamics of this population often involve heightened concerns around vulnerability and risk.
- Community reintegration factors: Restrictions on residency and supervision conditions for individuals with sex offense convictions often require alternative housing solutions that align with their specific legal and therapeutic needs.

By maintaining these eligibility criteria, the NGU program ensures a safe and supportive environment for all participants, fostering successful reintegration into the community.

6. Screening Process

The Never Give Up Transitional Living program follows a thorough screening process to ensure that individuals admitted to the program are appropriate for its structure and services. The screening process is designed to assess each applicant's suitability for the program and to ensure their needs align with the support provided.

Pre-Screening and Video Review:

- In-prison engagement is encouraged, where potential participants are asked to watch an informational video about the program while still incarcerated. This helps applicants gain a clear understanding of the program and its expectations before applying.
- Word-of-mouth recommendations within NDCS are crucial, and case workers and other incarcerated individuals often promote the program to eligible individuals. Building trust and connections with incarcerated individuals is key to recruiting appropriate candidates.

Application Submission and Phone Interview:

- An application is submitted by the prospective participant to Mr. Reilly. While the application is helpful, Shane places more emphasis on the phone interview to determine suitability for the program.
- After the application is submitted, the reentry coordinator informs Mr. Reilly about the applicant and sets up a time for the phone interview.
- The applicant calls Mr. Reilly at the pre-determined time.
- During the phone interview, eligibility is determined, as Mr. Reilly discusses the applicant's background, motivation, and readiness for the program.

Criminal History and Risk Assessment:

- Sex offenders are automatically excluded from the program due to safety concerns and the specific needs of this population. NDCS reentry staff will alert Mr. Reilly if any applicants have a history of sexual behaviors, and he will review their file for more information.
- All other applicants are considered on a case-by-case basis, with the understanding that the program is open to individuals with a broad range of backgrounds.

Final Determination and Notification:

- After the phone interview and background review, Mr. Reilly typically rejects very few applicants. The final decision about eligibility is based on the applicant's readiness, criminal history, and overall compatibility with the program's goals.
- Once accepted, applicants are provided with next steps and orientation information. If not accepted, they may be referred to other programs better suited to their needs.

Other Notes About Screening:

- Mr. Reilly has noted the need for a better referral process and has contracted with a University of Nebraska Omaha, School of Criminology and Criminal Justice professor to develop a more standardized and helpful process.
- Furthermore, Mr. Reilly believes targeting specific facilities like Omaha Correctional Center (OCC), Reception and Treatment Center (RTC), and Tecumseh State Correctional Institution would help improve program admission numbers.

7. Housing Model and Program Structure

The Never Give Up Transitional Living program follows a transitional housing model, offering participants a safe, stable environment while they work toward independent living.

Housing Details:

- **Location:** 4302 Fort Street, Omaha, NE
- **Capacity:** Eleven participants (expected to grow overtime)

- **Room arrangements:** Shared or individual room based on program tenure, individual progress, and availability. Participants begin in a shared room. As individuals progress through the program and demonstrate success, they may be eligible for the transition to an individual room.
- **Length of program:** 12 weeks / 84 days

Program Components:

The NGU program is designed to provide comprehensive support and structure to individuals as they transition back into the community. Each component addresses key factors that contribute to successful reintegration, including housing stability, employment opportunities, accountability measures, therapy designed to help with emotional regulation, family and community support, and access to essential services. By offering 24/7 supervision, workforce development, therapy, and community engagement, the program fosters personal growth and responsibility while reducing the risk of recidivism. The following sections outline the core components of the program:

A. 24/7 Supervision and Accountability

- Supervised, structured housing with clear rules and expectations
- Regular check-ins, required "coding in" to the house, camera surveillance, curfew, and mandatory participation in services
- Urinalysis if drug or alcohol use is suspected

B. Stable Housing

- A safe place to live for the duration of the program

C. Support Services

- Assistance with securing ID, social security number, birth certificate (as needed)
- Assistance with securing SNAP EBT benefits
- Assistance with securing Medicaid and primary care physician
- Accountability check-ins
- Provides food and clothing
- Provides cellphones, screen protector, case, and first month of plan paid
- Provides hygiene products and laundry detergent
- Provides transportation allowance to/from counseling sessions, AA/NA meetings, store, and employment through Uber

D. Employment and Workforce Development

- Job placement assistance through program
- Resume building, interview prep, and skills training through Metropolitan Community College's 180 Reentry Assistance Program (180 RAP)
- Volunteer work at Heart Ministry, if employment has not yet been secured

E. Therapy and Life Skills Development

- Required nightly group Dialectical Behavior Therapy sessions (3x/week)
- Required Intensive Outpatient Program sessions (2x/week)
- Required attendance at Alcoholics Anonymous (AA) and Narcotics Anonymous (NA) meetings (2-4x/week)
- Required financial literacy meetings (1x/week)
- Required to set up a checking and savings account
- Encouraged to set up a secured credit care and secured loan
- Sponsor Night from 6-9pm on Sundays (highly encouraged to get a sponsor)
- Individualized therapy, as needed, through a Licensed Independent Mental Health Practitioner (LIMHP)
- Peer mentorship and support to aid reintegration into the community

F. Family, Prosocial Peers, and Community Network (Re)Development

- Visitation event with approved family and friends on Sundays
- Family passes every other Sunday after being in the program for 30 days
- Church attendance at Brookside Church on Sundays
- Volunteer work at Christmas in the Village, Metro 360, and/or other events (e.g., Tornado cleanup)
- Pizza and taco nights during the week (Tuesday and Thursday)
- Prosocial event participation as a group on Saturdays (e.g., UNO and Creighton sporting events, Hot Shops Art Center, Beaver Lake)

8. Program Rules

By adhering to the below rules, participants contribute to a respectful and supportive environment that promotes successful reintegration into society:

Substance Use and Possessions:

- Smoking: Smoking or tobacco products are not allowed inside the residence. Smoking is permitted outside in the designated areas only. Smoking after 10:00pm is allowed, but it must be in the designated outside area.
- Prohibited Substances: Program participants must not possess, use, or be under the influence of illegal drugs or alcohol.
- Random Drug and Alcohol Testing: Failure to submit to a urinalysis when requested is cause for dismissal from the program.
- Medication Compliance: All medications must be checked and approved by staff.

Behavioral Conduct:

- Violence and Harassment: Any form of violence, harassment, or misconduct is strictly prohibited and may lead to removal from the program.
- No Weapons or Contraband: Possession of weapons, firearms, or contraband is strictly prohibited and may lead to removal from the program.
- No Involvement in Illegal Activities: Participants must refrain from engaging in illegal activities, including theft, assault, or other criminal behaviors. Violating this rule could result in immediate removal from the program.
- Respectful Interaction: Treat all staff and fellow program participants with respect; inappropriate behavior will not be tolerated. Treat others the way you want to be treated; if you don't have something nice to say, don't say anything at all.
- Respect for Property: If it's not yours, don't eat or touch it. All food and belongings should be respected and not taken without permission.
- No Gambling: Gambling of any kind is strictly prohibited on the premises.
- No Bars or Alcohol Establishments: Program participants are not permitted to be in bars or establishments that serve alcohol.

Personal Conduct and Dress Code:

- Personal Cleanliness: Personal hygiene must be maintained at all times. Take pride in your appearance.
- Self-Sufficiency: Participants are expected to be self-sufficient, managing their daily activities and responsibilities.
- Dress Code: Sleeve shirts must be worn at all times; no dirty shoes or bare feet allowed in the residence; no gang-affiliated, drug-related, or inappropriate clothing allowed; no sagging of pants.
- Gold Teeth: Gold teeth or any dental adornments (i.e., decorations, enhancements) that can be seen as gang-related or associated with criminal behavior are not permitted.

Housing Conduct:

- Room Assignments: Program participants will start in shared rooms; individual rooms may be assigned based on program tenure and compliance.
- Room Inspections: Regular room and house inspections will occur to ensure the living environment is clean, organized, and free from contraband.
- Room Cleanliness: Maintain personal and shared spaces; beds must be made daily, and rooms should pass daily inspections.
- House Cleanliness: Maintain shared living spaces. Kitchen, living room, and other common areas must be kept tidy and should pass daily inspections.
- Fire Safety: Fire extinguishers are for emergency use only; misuse may result in disciplinary action.
- Food and Drink: No food or drink is permitted in participants' bedrooms.

Guest and Visitation Policy:

- Communication with Family or Support Networks: Participants are encouraged to reestablish communication with family members or prosocial support networks, through this may be restricted or monitored depending on individual circumstances.
- Visiting Hours: Family visitation is every Sunday from 1:00pm to 6:00pm in designated areas. No guests are permitted in participants' bedrooms.
- Guest Restrictions: Visitors must be listed on participants' approved prison visitation list.

Program Compliance:

- Mandatory Participation in Group Activities: Participation in group meetings or activities designed to promote personal growth, such as life skills training, relapse prevention classes, and financial literacy/job readiness workshops, onsite and offsite, are required.
- Curfew: Program participants are required to be back at the house by 5:30pm each day. No overnight stays away from the house are allowed.
- Passes and Permission: All passes or special permissions (for example, having someone drop something off to you) must be approved by the Program Director, Shane Reilly. No other staff member can grant you permission to do anything.
- Ask Questions: If you don't know, ask. If you think you know, ask. And if you know you know, ask anyway. Things will go smoother.
- Compliance with Legal Conditions: Participants on parole must adhere to the specific legal conditions set by the court, such as no contact with certain individuals or maintaining a particular level of conduct. Attendance to scheduled meetings/contact with parole officer is required (NGU has one designated parole officer for participants).

Relapse and Violation of Program Rules:

- Relapse: We recognize that relapse can be a normal part of the recovery process for individuals with substance use disorders. At the same time, relapse offers an opportunity to learn, adjust, and grow. Because maintaining a safe and supportive environment is essential, NGU and parole have established the following policy for relapses that occur while you are in the program:
    - *First relapse:* You may be given a second chance to remain the program, depending on the circumstances and your willingness to engage in recovery.
    - *Second relapse:* You will be immediately removed from the program—no exceptions. However, you are still required to return to NGU to participate in Intensive Outpatient Programming (IOP) and individual counseling sessions.
- Violation of Rules: Breaking program rules may result in the loss of passes, loss of visiting privileges, additional counseling, or program termination.

9. Program Expectations

Participants of the Reentry Program are expected to participate fully in the program, which is designed to support their successful reintegration into society. The following are the core program components that outline the expectations of participants:

24/7 Supervision and Accountability:

- The reentry program provides supervised, structured housing with clearly defined rules and expectations. Adherence to these rules and expectations is required.
- Regular check-ins are required, along with mandatory "coding in" to the house, adherence to a curfew, and camera surveillance to ensure accountability and safety.
- Participants must comply with urinalysis testing if drug or alcohol use is suspected.
- Importantly, all activities (aside from employment) are done together. This is a "we" program and, therefore, we stand stronger together.

Employment and Workforce Development:

- Participants will engage in resume building, interview participation, and skills training through Metropolitan Community College's 180 Reentry Assistance Program (180 RAP).
- Participants are expected to obtain employment.
- If employment has not been secured, participants are expected to participate in volunteer work at Heart Ministry to gain work experience and contribute to the community.

Therapy, Recovery, Life Skills, and Community Reintegration:

- Dialectical Behavior Therapy (DBT) group counseling is required approximately three times per week from 6:00 to 7:00pm to support emotional regulation and interpersonal effectiveness.
- Intensive Outpatient Program (IOP) participation is required two times per week from 6:00 to 8:30pm to support mental health and substance use treatment.
- Alcoholics Anonymous (AA) and Narcotics Anonymous (NA) meetings are required two to four times per week to support sobriety.
- Participants are required to attend weekly financial literacy meetings to develop important budgeting and money management skills (Tuesday).
- On Fridays/Saturdays, participants must partake in prosocial group activities, such as attending University of Nebraska Omaha and Creighton sporting events, visiting the Hot Shops Art Center, or enjoying outdoor activities like Beaver Lake.
- Church attendance at Brookside Church on Sunday mornings (10:00am to 12:00pm) is required to help participants rebuild spiritual and/or social networks.
- Visitation events with approved family and friends are held on Sundays from 1:00pm to 6:00pm to encourage family reintegration. Participants are required to be in attendance.

- Sponsor Night takes place on Sundays from 6:00pm to 9:00pm to build supportive relationships with sponsors. During this time, sponsors can pick up participants from their reentry house.
- Individualized one-on-one therapy with a Licensed Independent Mental Health Practitioner (LIMHP) is available as needed.
- Volunteer work is required at community events, as applicable.
- Peer mentorship is offered to support participants in their transition back into the community and develop positive relationships.

Figure 2 displays an approximate Never Give Up Transitional Living program schedule of activities.

10. Partnerships and Community Support

The Never Give Up Transitional Living program has connected with several Omaha community organizations, two of which have already committed to donating to the program, including:

- Sherwood Foundation
- Omaha Community Foundation

The Never Give Up Transitional Living program does not currently have funding from parole or other criminal justice agencies. However, the program aims to continue its previous partnership with Nebraska Parole by securing a parole contract, replicating the previous arrangement established with 50th Street Landing under Mr. Reilly's leadership. The contract would be for a duration of 84 days per participant, at a rate of $90 per day per individual.

Furthermore, the Never Give Up Transitional Living program maintains strong partnerships with employers in the Omaha, Nebraska area, facilitating participants' access to high-quality employment opportunities during their involvement in the program.

11. Outcomes and Program Success

Program completion is based on two categories—successful and unsuccessful—defined as:

Successful Program Completion

- Participants must complete the required 84 days in the program, establish a comprehensive plan for continued success, commit to a foundation of recovery (e.g., AA, NA, church), and maintain a record free of relapses, arrests or violations, or significant setbacks during their participation.

Figure 2. Never Give Up Transitional Living approximate weekly schedule of activities

	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday	Saturday	Sunday
~ 5:00am to 7:00am	• Get up, make beds, get ready for day	• Get up, make beds, get ready for day	• Get up, make beds, get ready for day	• Get up, make beds, get ready for day	• Get up, make beds, get ready for day	• Get up, make beds, get ready for day	• Get up, make beds, get ready for day
~ 6:00am to 8:00am	• Go to work, via Uber • Visit 180 RAP	• Go to work, via Uber • Volunteer at Heart Ministries	• Go to work, via Uber • Volunteer at Heart Ministries	• Go to work, via Uber • Visit 180 Rap	• Go to work, via Uber • Volunteer at Heart Ministries	• Go to work, via Uber • AA meeting	
10:00am-12:00pm							• Brookside Church
12:30pm-5:30pm							• Group meal • Family/Friend Visitation
5:30pm	• Return from work, get settled	• Return from work, get settled	• Return from work, get settled	• Return from work, get settled	• Return from work, get settled	• Return from work, get settled	
6:00pm	• Intensive Outpatient Program	• Group financial literacy meeting	• Intensive Outpatient Program	• Group DBT session	• Group DBT session	• Group DBT session	• Sponsor night
7:00pm-8:30pm		• AA meeting		• NA meeting	• AA meeting • Social outing	• Social outing	
8:30pm-9:00pm	• Free night at the house	• Pizza Night	• Free night at the house	• Taco Thursday	• Free night at the house		

Abbreviations: RAP = Reentry Assistance Program, DBT = Dialectical Behavior Therapy, AA = Alcoholics Anonymous, NA = Narcotics Anonymous

Unsuccessful Program Completion

- Determinations regarding unsuccessful completion are typical made by the program leadership. Participants will be removed for a second relapse and may be removed from the program for serious infractions of program expectations.
- On rare occasions, Mr. Reilly makes the sole determination to remove a participant from the program (e.g., the use of Synthetic Cannabinoids [Spice/K2] is an automatic removal from the program) without warning.
- On these occasions, Mr. Reilly must report to the participants' parole officer, as step one of parole is typically to complete transitional living.

The overall success of the Never Give Up Transitional Living program will be measured by:

- **Employment:** Percent of participants securing jobs and duration of employment
- **Maintain Sobriety:** Urinalysis test results, parole technical violations, and self-reports
- **Develop Healthy Coping Skills:** Self-report
- **Build and Maintain Positive Relationships:** Self-report
- **Financial Literacy:** Documentation of a checking and savings account
- **Community Belonging:** Self-report
- **Life Skills:** Self-report
- **Plan for Success After Program:** Documentation and self-report
- **Recidivism Rate:** Percent of participants rearrested, reconvicted, and/or returning to prison within three years of release
- **Successful Program Completion:** Graduation from the program

12. Staffing and Ongoing Support

The Never Give Up Transitional Living program will be staffed by a team of professionals with lived experiences who are committed to providing high-quality reentry and peer support services. The team will work at the reentry house throughout its operation and ensure that participants receive the comprehensive care and guidance they need.

Key Staff and Roles: *(See Employee Role Descriptions document for more information)*

- Non-Profit Board of Directors: The Board of Directors of Good Turn Labor LLC provides strategic leadership, governance, and oversight to ensure NGU's mission is fulfilled with integrity and effectiveness. The Board is responsible for fiduciary stewardship, long-term visioning, organizational policy, and supporting the Executive Director and program staff.
- Executive Director: The Executive Director provides overall leadership, vision, and direction for the organization. They focus on external partnership, stakeholder

engagement, and long-term sustainability while ensuring the program aligns with its mission. They collaborate with the Board of Directors on governance and financial oversight but delegate day-to-day program operations to the Program Director.
    - Julie Micek, LIMHP

- Program Director: The Program Director is responsible for the daily management and operational success of the transitional living program. They oversee program staff, ensure service quality, and maintain compliance with funding and regulatory requirements. The Program Director is the primary decision-maker for participant intake, service coordination, and program implementation, ensuring smooth internal operations. They oversee facility operations, logistics, and compliance to ensure the smooth functioning of the program.
    - Shane Reilly, MS
- Assistant Program Director: The Assistant Program Director provides operational support, assists in staff supervision, and coordinates participant services. They help ensure program efficiency and effectiveness.
    - Jimmy King
- Case Manager: The Case Manager provides individualized support to participants, helping them navigate employment and reentry challenges.
    - Brian Hafley
- Peer Support Specialists: The Peer Support Specialist provides mentorship, guidance, and emotional support to participants, using lived experience with incarceration and successful reentry to foster connection and encouragement. Current peer support specialists include:
    - Muthang Choule
    - Justin Seffron
    - Jacob Thore
- Resident Manager: The Resident Manager ensures a safe, structured, and supportive living environment for participants in transitional housing. They enforce program rules, provide on-site support, and help maintain a positive, accountable, and community-oriented atmosphere.
    - Jimmy King
- Health Support and Counseling Specialist: A licensed therapist will be available, as needed, to participants for mental health, emotional support, thinking patterns, and substance abuse counseling. The goal is to address the specific needs of participants who are struggling with mental health, negative thinking and emotional patterns, or addiction issues.
    - Julie Micek, LIMHP
    - Shane Reilly, MS

- Intensive Outpatient Program (IOP) Instructor: The IOP Instructor leads structured group and individual sessions to help clients build coping skills, process experiences, and work toward recovery goals.
- Development Director (Fundraising and Grants): The Development Director leads fundraising efforts, including grants, donations, and partnerships, to sustain the program. They must build employer partnerships, community relationships, and reentry awareness.
    - Shane Reilly, MS
- Grant Writer (Contract Position): The Grant Writer researchers, writes, and submits grant applications to secure funding for the program.
- Accounting Firm (External Service): An external accounting firm handles financial reporting, compliance, and budgeting to ensure fiscal responsibility.

Together, this team ensures that individuals returning from incarceration receive the comprehensive support needed to rebuild their lives, secure stable employment and housing, and successfully reintegrate into their communities.

13. Conclusion

The Never Give Up Transitional Living program offers a structured, supportive environment for individuals transitioning from incarceration in the Nebraska Department of Correctional Services. By combining quality employment, stable housing, drug and alcohol treatment, dialectical behavior therapy, life skills, and (re)establishing a community support network, the Never Give Up Transitional Living program is committed to helping individuals rebuild their lives and successfully reintegrate into society. Additionally, by having a director with lived experience, Mr. Reilly "gets it" and can relate to the men in the program in a way unlike others who do not have such experiences.

For more information or referrals, please contact:
Shane Reilly | 402.359.7404 | ngutlomaha@gmail.com

Appendix B. Participant Application Form

Never Give Up Transitional Living

Program Application

Never Give Up (NGU) Transitional Living is a 12-week structured, sober transitional living program designed to support formerly incarcerated individuals as they reintegrate into the community. The program provides safe, stable housing alongside employment support, dialectical behavior therapy, life skills training, social support, and more to improve long-term outcomes. Additionally, NGU is staffed by a team of professionals with lived experiences—they have been incarcerated and since turned their lives around—who are committed to providing high-quality reentry and peer support services.

You may apply up to four months before your anticipated release date. Contact us if you need assistance filling out the application.

Individuals convicted of sex offenses or on the sex offender registry are not permitted to participate in NGU Transitional Living. *We encourage you to seek out alternative programs.*

To be accepted into NGU Transitional Living an applicant must complete this application, in full, and be interviewed by the program director. Carefully read the application and honestly answer the questions. *Living at NGU Transitional Living is special and if you understand its value, it can help you achieve comfortable sobriety without relapse.*

Print Name (First, Middle, Last): _____

Date of Birth: _____/_____/_____

What is your marital status? Never Married ☐ Married ☐ Separated/Divorced ☐ Other ☐

Do you have dependent children? Yes ☐ No ☐

- If Yes, how old are they? _____
- Do you have legal custody of your dependent children? Yes ☐ No ☐

Do you or will you receive welfare or other non-job-related income (i.e., disability)?

Yes ☐ No ☐

Are you an alcoholic? Yes ☐ No ☐

- Date of your last drink: _____/_____/_____

Are you addicted to drugs? Yes ☐ No ☐

- Date of last drug use: _____/_____/_____
- List of drugs you have used addictively: _____

Do you attend AA or NA meetings? Yes ☐ No ☐

- If Yes, how many AA/NA meetings do you attend each week? _____

Have you ever been to a treatment facility for alcoholism or drug addiction? Yes ☐ No ☐

- If Yes, what was the name of the treatment facility? _____
- If Yes, when did you attend the treatment facility? _____/_____/_____

Do you take prescription drugs? Yes ☐ No ☐

- If Yes, list the drug(s) and reason the drug(s) has/have been prescribed:
  _____

Do you have a medical doctor? Yes ☐ No ☐

- If Yes, list the their name and phone number: _____

Do you have a therapist/counselor/psychiatrist? Yes ☐ No ☐

- If Yes, list the their name and phone number: _____

Are you currently incarcerated? Yes ☐ No ☐

- If No, when were you released from incarceration? _____/_____/_____
- If Yes, what is your anticipated release date/parole hearing? _____/_____/_____
  - Where are you incarcerated: _____

In order for NGU to maintain our waiting list, we need to have quick access to accurate information regarding parole/discharge dates. Please provide contact information for your reentry case worker below.

Reentry Case Worker Name: _____

Reentry Case Worker Phone Number: _____

When would you like to move into NGU Transitional Living? Now ☐ Other Date ☐

- If "other," list the date you would want to move in, if accepted, and why the date is in the future rather than immediately.

  Date: _____/_____/_____

  Reason: _____

Have you lived in a transitional living or ¾ way house before? Yes ☐ No ☐

- If Yes, what was the name of the house? _____
- If Yes, why did you leave the house? _____
- If Yes, do you owe money to the house you left? Yes ☐ No ☐
  - If you owe money to the house you left, please confirm this statement: *I agree to repay the money I owe to my former transitional living or ¾ way house.* Yes ☐ No ☐

Personal Statement: Why do you want to be a part of Never Give Up Transitional Living?

Emergency Telephone Numbers (list doctor, if you have one, + family members or friends):

Name and Address	Relationship	Telephone Number
1.		
2.		
3.		

Please review this summary of some of the house rules. These rules apply to every program participant, are not negotiable, and serious or repeated violations will lead to program removal. If you are selected for the house, you must sign an agreement that will include these, and other, rules.

- **No drug or alcohol use or possession.**
- **Smoking or tobacco products are not allowed inside the residence.**
- **All program participants are expected to maintain a peaceful and respectful environment for their housemates.** Any form of violence, harassment, or misconduct is strictly prohibited.
- **Possession of weapons, firearms, or contraband is strictly prohibited.**
- **Program participants must refrain from engaging in illegal activities.**
- **All food and belongings should be respected and not taken without permission.**
- **Gambling of any kind is strictly prohibited on the premises.**
- **Personal hygiene must be maintained at all times.**
- **Sleeve shirts must be worn at all times; no gang-affiliated, drug-related, or inappropriate clothing allowed; no sagging.**
- **Gold teeth or any dental adornments are not permitted.**
- **Maintain personal and shared spaces**; beds must be made daily and rooms and shared spaces should pass daily inspections.
- **Family visitation is every Sunday from 1:00pm to 6:00pm in designated areas. No guests are permitted in participants' bedrooms. Visitors must be listed on program participants' approved prison visitation list.**
- **Participation in all group meetings or activities designed to promote personal growth are required.** These activities include, but are not limited to, nightly group counseling sessions, AA/NA meetings, prosocial group outings, and church attendance.
- **Program participants are expected to obtain employment.**
- **Program participants are required to be back at the house by 5:30pm each day.** No overnight stays away from the house are allowed.
- **Program participants must comply with all parole, probation, or other Nebraska Department of Correctional Services mandated requirements.**

Use this space for additional relevant information:

SIGNATURE: All applicants must sign application.

I have read all of the material on this application form including the above limitations. I understand that Never Give Up Transitional Living is relying on this information to prove my eligibility. I certify that all information and answers provided are true and complete to the best of my knowledge. I understand that providing false information or making false statements may be grounds for denial of my application. I verify that I want to achieve comfortable recovery from alcoholism and/or drug addiction without relapse.

Signature: _____ Date: _____/_____/_____

Appendix C. Phone Screening Guide

Never Give Up Transitional Living:

Phone Screening Interview Guide

Introduction:

Hello, my name is [interviewer's name], and I am reaching out on behalf of the Never Give Up Transitional Living program. This is an 84-day, structured, sober living program designed to support individuals like you as you transition back into the community after incarceration. What makes this program different is that it is entirely run by people who have been through it too—all of us, myself included, have done time. We understand the real challenges that come with reentry, and we are here to walk that path with you. Never Give Up is a "we" program—no one does this alone.

I have already reviewed your application, so today's conversation is a chance for us to talk more about your goals, your readiness for change, and how we can support you. There are no right or wrong answers here, just be honest and real. That's the one way this works.

Section 1: Substance Use

I want to start by talking about substance use. Never Give Up is a sober living program—that means no using, no selling, no substances in the house. We know from experience that staying clean is key to making real change. We're not here to judge, just to understand where you're at and if this program is the right fit.

1. Tell me a little bit about your history with drugs/alcohol.
    a. Do you believe drugs/alcohol have caused problems in your life?
    b. Have you ever tried to stop using/drinking before?
        i. What did that look like?
    c. Have you been to treatment or attended meetings?
        i. What worked and didn't work for you in previous programs or meetings?
2. What got you into prison?
3. What do you see as the biggest challenge you'll face in reentry?

Section 2: Commitment to Structure

I want to walk you through what day-to-day life looks like at Never Give Up. This program is about more than just staying out—it's about building a new routine and focusing on your recovery. That means waking up early, making your bed, staying clean, working, and being around others who are trying to change too.

1. While you are here you will attend IOP. Do you have a problem with that?
2. Tuesday, Wednesday, and Thursday, you will attend AA or NA. Do you have a problem with that?
3. On Sunday's we attend church. Do you have a problem with that?

4. You will also be expected to keep your space clean, participate in programming activities, follow the house rules and expectations, and work. We'll help you find a job, but the focus here is not just working—it's healing, staying sober, and staying free. This is about your life, are you committed to changing your lifestyle?

Section 3: Motivational and Readiness for Change

1. What are your biggest motivations for wanting to make a change *right now*?

2. How important is it for you to stay out of prison permanently – would you say that's not very important, somewhat important, or very important?
    a. What makes you say that?

3. How confident do you feel about your ability to stay out of prison permanently – not very confident, somewhat confident, or very confident?
    a. What makes you feel that level of confidence?

4. To what extent are you *trying* to stay out of prison permanently right now – would you say you're not really trying yet, making some effort, or giving it your full effort?
    a. OPTION A: What does that effort look like for you right now?
    b. OPTION B: What helps you keep trying, even when it's hard?

5. In your application, you shared why you're interested in this program. Can you tell me more about that—what are you hoping to gain from this experience?

Section 4: Practical Considerations

1. When do you see the Board of Parole?
2. When are you paroling?
3. [IF MENTIONED BY APPLICANT] Do you have any plans lined up for employment while in the program?

Closing Statement:

Thanks for taking the time to talk with me today—I appreciate your honesty. What you shared helps us figure out how we can best support you. We will review your responses and follow up with the next steps soon. Do you have any questions for me before we wrap up?

Applicant Name: _____

Post-Screening Reflection (Interviewer Only)

Instructions: After completing the screening, rate your overall impressions based on the applicant's tone, comments, and attitude. Use your professional judgement – these ratings are meant to capture *how* the person engaged, not just *what* they said.

Please rate each statement from 1 (strongly disagree) to 4 (strongly agree):

1. The applicant appeared genuinely motivated to engage in the program. 1 – 2 – 3 – 4
2. The applicant showed openness to structure and feedback. 1 – 2 – 3 – 4
3. The applicant appeared defensive or resistant toward program expectations or requirements. 1 – 2 – 3 – 4
4. The applicant displayed signs of entitlement (e.g., expecting special treatment, setting conditions for participation). 1 – 2 – 3 – 4
5. The applicant seemed focused on what the program could offer them, rather than what they could contribute. 1 – 2 – 3 – 4
6. The applicant appeared self-aware and accountable for past choices. 1 – 2 – 3 – 4
7. The applicant demonstrated realistic expectations about work, privileges, and requirements. 1 – 2 – 3 – 4
8. The applicant questioned the program excessively or expressed frustration about requirements. 1 – 2 – 3 – 4

How would you describe this applicant's general readiness for the program?

a. Not ready – resistant, entitled, or unmotivated
b. Ambivalent – some openness but hesitant or self-serving motives
c. Ready – engaged, realistic, and self-motivated

Briefly describe any comments or behaviors that shaped your impression (e.g., asked about weekend passes, dismissed treatment needs, says he will only work for $#/hour).

Appendix D. Rules and Expectations Document

Never Give Up Transitional Living

Rules and Expectations

14. Program Rules

By adhering to the below rules, participants contribute to a respectful and supportive environment that promotes successful reintegration into society:

Substance Use and Possessions:

- Smoking: Smoking or tobacco products are not allowed inside the residence. Smoking is permitted outside in the designated areas only. Smoking after 10:00pm is allowed, but it must be in the designated outside area.
- Prohibited Substances: Program participants must not possess, use, or be under the influence of illegal drugs or alcohol.
- Random Drug and Alcohol Testing: Failure to submit to a urinalysis is cause for dismissal from the program.
- Medication Compliance: All medications must be checked and approved by staff.

Behavioral Conduct:

- Violence and Harassment: Any form of violence, harassment, or misconduct is strictly prohibited and may lead to removal from the program.
- No Weapons or Contraband: Possession of weapons, firearms, or contraband is strictly prohibited and may lead to removal from the program.
- No Involvement in Illegal Activities: Participants must refrain from engaging in illegal activities, including theft, assault, or other criminal behaviors. Violating this rule could result in immediate removal from the program.
- Respectful Interaction: Treat all staff and fellow program participants with respect; inappropriate behavior will not be tolerated. Treat others the way you want to be treated; if you don't have something nice to say, don't say anything at all.
- Respect for Property: If it's not yours, don't eat or touch it. All food and belongings should be respected and not taken without permission.
- No Gambling: Gambling of any kind is strictly prohibited on the premises.
- No Bars or Alcohol Establishments: Program participants are not permitted to be in bars or establishments that serve alcohol.

Personal Conduct and Dress Code:

- Personal Cleanliness: Personal hygiene must be maintained at all times. Take pride in your appearance.

- Self-Sufficiency: Participants are expected to be self-sufficient, managing their daily activities and responsibilities.
- Dress Code: Sleeve shirts must be worn at all times; no dirty shoes or bare feet allowed in the residence; no gang-affiliated, drug-related, or inappropriate clothing allowed; no sagging of pants.
- Gold Teeth: Gold teeth or any dental adornments (i.e., decorations, enhancements) that can be seen as gang-related or associated with criminal behavior are not permitted.

Housing Conduct:

- Room Assignments: Program participants will start in shared rooms; individual rooms may be assigned based on program tenure and compliance.
- Room Inspections: Regular room and house inspections will occur to ensure the living environment is clean, organized, and free from contraband.
- Room Cleanliness: Maintain personal and shared spaces; beds must be made daily, and rooms should pass daily inspections.
- House Cleanliness: Maintain shared living spaces. Kitchen, living room, and other common areas must be kept tidy and should pass daily inspections.
- Fire Safety: Fire extinguishers are for emergency use only; misuse may result in disciplinary action.
- Food and Drink: No food or drink is permitted in participants' bedrooms.

Guest and Visitation Policy:

- Communication with Family or Support Networks: Participants are encouraged to reestablish communication with family members or prosocial support networks, through this may be restricted or monitored depending on individual circumstances.
- Visiting Hours: Family visitation is every Sunday from 1:00pm to 6:00pm in designated areas. No guests are permitted in participants' bedrooms.
- Family Passes: After 30 days in the program, participants can receive family passes every other Sunday.
- Guest Restrictions: Visitors must be listed on participants' approved prison visitation list.

Program Compliance:

- Mandatory Participation in Group Activities: Participation in group meetings or activities designed to promote personal growth, such as life skills training, relapse prevention classes, and financial literacy/job readiness workshops, onsite and offsite, are required.
- Curfew: Program participants are required to be back at the house by 5:30pm each day. No overnight stays away from the house are allowed.
- Passes and Permission: All passes or special permissions (for example, having someone drop something off to you) must be approved by the Program Director, Shane Reilly. No other staff member can grant you permission to do anything.

- Ask Questions: If you don't know, ask. If you think you know, ask. And if you know you know, ask anyway. Things will go smoother.
- Compliance with Legal Conditions: Participants on parole must adhere to the specific legal conditions set by the court, such as no contact with certain individuals or maintaining a particular level of conduct. Attendance to scheduled meetings/contact with parole officer is required.
- Relapse or Violation of Rules: Violation to any rule may result in the loss of passes, loss of visiting privileges, additional counseling, or program termination.

15. Program Expectations

Participants of the Reentry Program are expected to participate fully in the program, which is designed to support their successful reintegration into society. The following are the core program components that outline the expectations of participants:

24/7 Supervision and Accountability:

- The reentry program provides supervised, structured housing with clearly defined rules and expectations. Adherence to these rules and expectations is required.
- Regular check-ins are required, along with mandatory "coding in" to the house, adherence to a curfew, and camera surveillance to ensure accountability and safety.
- Participants must comply with urinalysis testing if drug or alcohol use is suspected.
- Importantly, all activities (aside from employment) are done together. This is a "we" program and, therefore, we stand stronger together.

Employment and Workforce Development:

- Participants will engage in resume building, interview participation, and skills training through Metropolitan Community College's 180 Reentry Assistance Program (180 RAP).
- Participants are expected to obtain employment.
- If employment has not been secured, participants are expected to participate in volunteer work at Heart Ministry to gain work experience and contribute to the community.

Therapy, Recovery, Life Skills, and Community Reintegration:

- Dialectical Behavior Therapy (DBT) group counseling is required approximately five times per week at 6:00pm to support emotional regulation and interpersonal effectiveness.
- Alcoholics Anonymous (AA) and Narcotics Anonymous (NA) meetings are required four to five times per week to support sobriety.
- Participants are required to attend weekly financial literacy meetings to develop important budgeting and money management skills (group counseling meeting on Wednesday).

- On Fridays/Saturdays, participants must partake in prosocial group activities, such as attending University of Nebraska Omaha and Creighton sporting events, visiting the Hot Shops Art Center, or enjoying outdoor activities like Beaver Lake.
- Church attendance at Brookside Church on Sunday mornings (10:00am to 12:00pm) is required to help participants rebuild spiritual and/or social networks.
- Visitation events with approved family and friends are held on Sundays from 1:00pm to 6:00pm to encourage family reintegration. Participants are required to be in attendance.
- Sponsor Night takes place on Sundays from 6:00pm to 9:00pm to build supportive relationships with sponsors. During this time, sponsors can pick up participants from their reentry house.
- Individualized one-on-one therapy with a Licensed Independent Mental Health Practitioner (LIMHP) is available as needed.
- Volunteer work is required at community events, as applicable.
- Peer mentorship is offered to support participants in their transition back into the community and develop positive relationships.

Appendix E. Employee Role Descriptions

Never Give Up Transitional Living

Employee Role Descriptions

The Never Give Up Transitional Living Program is a structured transitional housing program operated under the nonprofit 501(c)(3) organization, Good Turn Labor, to support formerly incarcerated individuals as they reintegrate into the community. The program provides safe, stable housing alongside employment support, dialectical behavioral therapy, life skills training, social support, and more to reduce recidivism and improve long-term outcomes. Our team provides comprehensive reentry services, including case management, peer mentorship, housing, employment assistance, and mental health services. Each staff member plays a crucial role in creating a structured, supportive, and empowering environment for participants.

Leadership and Administration

Executive Director

- Reports To: Board of Directors
- Job Summary: The Executive Director provides overall leadership, vision, and direction for the organization. They focus on external partnership, stakeholder engagement, and long-term sustainability while ensuring the program aligns with its mission. They collaborate with the Board of Directors on governance and financial oversight but delegate day-to-day program operations to the Program Director.
- Key Responsibilities:
    - Develop and implement strategic goals and policies in collaboration with the Board of Directors
    - Serve as the primary representative to external stakeholders, funders, and policymakers
    - Advocate for reentry policy improvements and build partnerships with community organizations
    - Oversee organizational sustainability, fundraising efforts, and financial planning in coordination with the Development Director and accounting firm
    - Supervise and support the Program Director, ensuring alignment with the program's mission and goals
    - Promote professional development and capacity-building across the organization
- Qualifications:
    - Bachelor's or Master's degree in Nonprofit Management, Social Work, Criminal Justice, or a related field
    - 5+ years of leadership experience in a nonprofit or reentry-related organization
    - Strong public speaking, advocacy, and relationship-building skills

Program Director

- Reports To: Executive Director
- Job Summary: The Program Director is responsible for the daily management and operational success of the transitional living program. They oversee program staff, ensure service quality, and maintain compliance with funding and regulatory requirements. The Program Director is the primary decision-maker for participant intake, service coordination, and program implementation, ensuring smooth internal operations. They oversee facility operations, logistics, and compliance to ensure the smooth functioning of the program.
- Key Responsibilities:
    - Supervise and coordinate case managers, peer support staff, resident managers, and other program staff
    - Develop, refine, and enforce program policies and procedures
    - Oversee program implementation and ensure service delivery meets participant needs
    - Monitor program outcomes, compliance with funding requirements, and adherence to legal and regulatory standards
    - Build and maintain partnerships with service providers, referral agencies, and parole agencies
    - Ensure staff receive proper training and support
    - Screen and accept potential program participants based on eligibility criteria
    - Make determinations regarding participant removal in accordance with program policies and parole agency guidelines
    - Correspond with the parole board and parole agencies regarding participant progress and compliance
    - Provide direct supervision and guidance to the Assistant Program Director
    - Oversee facility management, housing logistics, and procurement of supplies
    - Ensure compliance with program policies, reentry housing regulations, and safety standards
    - Manage operational systems, scheduling, and efficiency improvements
    - Collaborate with the accounting firm on budget planning and financial compliance (not direct bookkeeping)
    - Supervise administrative staff and ensure smooth daily operations
- Qualifications:
    - Bachelor's or Master's degree in Social Work, Criminal Justice, or a related field
    - 3+ years of experience in program management, preferably in reentry services
    - Strong organizational and leadership skills
    - Lived experience with incarceration and successful reentry

Assistant Program Director

- Reports To: Program Director

- Job Summary: The Assistant Program Director provides operational support, assists in staff supervision, and coordinates participant services. They help ensure program efficiency and effectiveness.
- Key Responsibilities:
    - Assist in managing daily operations and service delivery
    - Support case managers and peer support specialists in their roles
    - Oversee participant intake and ensure smooth transitions
    - Back up Program Director in their absence
- Qualifications:
    - Bachelor's degree in Social Support, Criminal Justice, or a related field (or equivalent experience)
    - 2+ years of experience in reentry services or program support
    - Strong organizational and leadership skills
    - Lived experience with incarceration and successful reentry

Case Management and Client Services

Case Manager

- Reports To: Program Director
- Job Summary: The Case Manager provides individualized support to participants, helping them navigate employment and reentry challenges.
- Key Responsibilities:
    - Conduct intake assessments, orientation, and develop personalized reentry plans
    - Assist participants with job readiness (resume building, interview prep, job searches)
    - Partner with local employers for job placement opportunities
    - Connect participants with post-program housing, job training, and mental health services
    - Provide non-clinical crisis support by helping participants navigate difficult situations and access relevant resources
    - Provide ongoing case management
    - Maintain case notes and track participant progress
    - Manage data tracking systems for program performance, participant outcomes, and operational metrics
- Qualifications:
    - Bachelor's degree in Social Work, Criminal Justice, or a related field (or equivalent experience)
    - 2+ years of case management or social services experience
    - Strong interpersonal and problem-solving skills
    - Experience with data tracking and reporting systems
    - Lived experience with incarceration and successful reentry

Peer Support Specialist

- Reports To: Program Director
- Job Summary: The Peer Support Specialist provides mentorship, guidance, and emotional support to participants, using lived experience with incarceration and successful reentry to foster connection and encouragement
- Key Responsibilities:
    - Build trusting relationships with participants through shared experiences
    - Offer emotional support and guidance during the reentry process
    - Assist participants with navigating reentry challenges, such as housing, employment, and social reintegration
    - Facilitate peer support groups and one-on-one mentorship sessions
    - Encourage personal accountability and goal setting for successful reintegration
    - Connect participants to community resources, support networks, and available services
- Qualifications:
    - Lived experience with incarceration and successful reentry
    - Strong communication and mentorship skills
    - Passion for helping others succeed in their reentry journey

Resident Manager

- Reports To: Program Director
- Job Summary: The Resident Manager ensures a safe, structured, and supportive living environment for participants in transitional housing. They enforce program rules, provide on-site support, and help maintain a positive, accountable, and community-oriented atmosphere.
- Key Responsibilities:
    - Supervise daily activities within the transitional housing facility
    - Enforce program rules and maintain a safe, structured living environment
    - Provide guidance and support to residents, helping them navigate challenges
    - Monitor and address conflicts or behavioral concerns as they arise
    - Conduct regular room checks and ensure compliance with housing policies
    - Report concerns or violations to the Program Director
    - Encourage accountability and positive peer interactions among residents
    - Coordinate with case managers and peer support specialists to support resident needs
- Qualifications:
    - Experience in housing management, residential support, or social services
    - Strong conflict resolution and communication skills
    - Ability to maintain structure and enforce rules while providing guidance
    - Willingness to work non-traditional hours, including evening or weekends as needed

- Lived experience with incarceration and successful reentry

Health Support and Counseling Specialist

- Reports To: Program Director
- Job Summary: The Health Support and Counseling Specialist provides mental health and wellness support for program participants
- Key Responsibilities:
  - Offer individual or group counseling services
  - Connect participants with mental health and substance use treatment programs
  - Provide education on coping strategies and emotional regulation
  - Collaborate with case managers to support participants' wellbeing
- Qualifications:
  - Licensed mental health counselor or social worker, with expertise in substance use or trauma-informed care
  - Experience working in reentry or similar high-need environments

Community Engagement and Outreach

Development Director (Fundraising and Grants)

- Reports To: Executive Director
- Job Summary: The Development Director leads fundraising efforts, including grants, donations, and partnerships, to sustain the program. They must build employer partnerships, community relationships, and reentry awareness
- Key Responsibilities:
  - Develop and implement fundraising strategies
  - Cultivate relationships with individual donors and corporate sponsors
  - Organize fundraising events and campaigns
  - Work closely with the grant writer to align funding efforts
  - Develop and maintain partnerships with employers willing to hire justice-involved individuals
  - Organize outreach events, workshops, and community engagement activities
  - Advocate for program participants and educate the community about reentry challenges
- Qualifications:
  - Bachelor's degree in Nonprofit Management, Business, or a related field (or equivalent experience)
  - Experience in fundraising and donor relations
  - Strong networking skills

Grant Writing and Financial Management

Grant Writer (Contract Position)

- Reports To: Executive Director
- Job Summary: The Grant Writer researchers, writes, and submits grant applications to secure funding for the program
- Key Responsibilities:
    - Identify and apply for relevant grants
    - Write compelling proposals and reports
    - Ensure compliance with grant requirements and deadlines
    - Work with program staff to gather necessary data for applications

Accounting Firm (External Service)

- Reports To: Executive Director
- Job Summary: An external accounting firm handles financial reporting, compliance, and budgeting to ensure fiscal responsibility
- Key Responsibilities:
    - Manage financial reporting and ensure regulatory compliance
    - Oversee budgeting and financial planning
    - Work with leadership to provide financial transparency and accountability

Together, this team ensures that individuals returning from incarceration receive the comprehensive support needed to rebuild their lives, secure stable employment and housing, and successfully reintegrate into their communities.

Appendix F. Program Orientation Form

Never Give Up Transitional Living

Orientation, Rules and Expectations, and Checklist

Print Name (First, Middle, Last): _____

Date Entered NGU Transitional Living: _____/_____/_____

NGU Transitional Living Orientation:

NGU Overview:

- Explain the goal of the program: ☐ Completed
    - Date explained: _____/_____/_____
- House tour and explain living arrangements: ☐ Completed
    - Date completed: _____/_____/_____
- Explain approximate program schedule: ☐ Completed
    - Date completed: _____/_____/_____
- Explain emergency procedures and safety protocols: ☐ Completed
    - Date completed: _____/_____/_____
- Provide contact information for program director and case manager: ☐ Completed
    - Date completed: _____/_____/_____

NGU Rules and Program Expectations:

- Participant read and sign house rules and expectations (pp. 2-5) and case manager answer any questions: ☐ Completed
    - Date completed: _____/_____/_____
    - Notes: _____

Case Manager fill out NGU Orientation Checklist with participant (pp. 6-9)

- The majority of these elements should be established within the first week.*
- *Exceptions: obtaining employment and establishing financial accounts may not be completed within the first week but should be completed as soon as possible.

NGU Transitional Living Rules and Expectations:

Program Rules

By adhering to the below rules, participants contribute to a respectful and supportive environment that promotes successful reintegration into society:

Substance Use and Possessions:

- Smoking: Smoking or tobacco products are not allowed inside the residence. Smoking is permitted outside in the designated areas only. Smoking after 10:00pm is allowed, but it must be in the designated outside area.
- Prohibited Substances: Program participants must not possess, use, or be under the influence of illegal drugs or alcohol.
- Random Drug and Alcohol Testing: Failure to submit to a urinalysis is cause for dismissal from the program.
- Medication Compliance: All medications must be checked and approved by staff.

Behavioral Conduct:

- Violence and Harassment: Any form of violence, harassment, or misconduct is strictly prohibited and may lead to removal from the program.
- No Weapons or Contraband: Possession of weapons, firearms, or contraband is strictly prohibited and may lead to removal from the program.
- No Involvement in Illegal Activities: Participants must refrain from engaging in illegal activities, including theft, assault, or other criminal behaviors. Violating this rule could result in immediate removal from the program.
- Respectful Interaction: Treat all staff and fellow program participants with respect; inappropriate behavior will not be tolerated. Treat others the way you want to be treated; if you don't have something nice to say, don't say anything at all.
- Respect for Property: If it's not yours, don't eat or touch it. All food and belongings should be respected and not taken without permission.
- No Gambling: Gambling of any kind is strictly prohibited on the premises.
- No Bars or Alcohol Establishments: Program participants are not permitted to be in bars or establishments that serve alcohol.

Personal Conduct and Dress Code:

- Personal Cleanliness: Personal hygiene must be maintained at all times. Take pride in your appearance.
- Self-Sufficiency: Participants are expected to be self-sufficient, managing their daily activities and responsibilities.

- Dress Code: Sleeve shirts must be worn at all times; no dirty shoes or bare feet allowed in the residence; no gang-affiliated, drug-related, or inappropriate clothing allowed; no sagging of pants.
- Gold Teeth: Gold teeth or any dental adornments (i.e., decorations, enhancements) that can be seen as gang-related or associated with criminal behavior are not permitted.

Housing Conduct:

- Room Assignments: Program participants will start in shared rooms; individual rooms may be assigned based on program tenure and compliance.
- Room Inspections: Regular room and house inspections will occur to ensure the living environment is clean, organized, and free from contraband.
- Room Cleanliness: Maintain personal and shared spaces; beds must be made daily, and rooms should pass daily inspections.
- House Cleanliness: Maintain shared living spaces. Kitchen, living room, and other common areas must be kept tidy and should pass daily inspections.
- Fire Safety: Fire extinguishers are for emergency use only; misuse may result in disciplinary action.
- Food and Drink: No food or drink is permitted in participants' bedrooms.

Guest and Visitation Policy:

- Communication with Family or Support Networks: Participants are encouraged to reestablish communication with family members or prosocial support networks, through this may be restricted or monitored depending on individual circumstances.
- Visiting Hours: Family visitation is every Sunday from 1:00pm to 6:00pm in designated areas. No guests are permitted in participants' bedrooms.
- Family Passes: After 30 days in the program, participants can receive family passes every other Sunday.
- Guest Restrictions: Visitors must be listed on participants' approved prison visitation list.

Program Compliance:

- Mandatory Participation in Group Activities: Participation in group meetings or activities designed to promote personal growth, such as life skills training, relapse prevention classes, and financial literacy/job readiness workshops, onsite and offsite, are required.
- Curfew: Program participants are required to be back at the house by 5:30pm each day. No overnight stays away from the house are allowed.
- Passes and Permission: All passes or special permissions (for example, having someone drop something off to you) must be approved by the Program Director, Shane Reilly. No other staff member can grant you permission to do anything.
- Ask Questions: If you don't know, ask. If you think you know, ask. And if you know you know, ask anyway. Things will go smoother.

- Compliance with Legal Conditions: Participants on parole must adhere to the specific legal conditions set by the court, such as no contact with certain individuals or maintaining a particular level of conduct. Attendance to scheduled meetings/contact with parole officer is required (NGU has one designated parole officer for participants).

Relapse and Violation of Program Rules:

- Relapse: We recognize that relapse can be a normal part of the recovery process for individuals with substance use disorders. At the same time, relapse offers an opportunity to learn, adjust, and grow. Because maintaining a safe and supportive environment is essential, NGU and parole have established the following policy for relapses that occur while you are in the program:
    - *First relapse:* You may be given a second chance to remain the program, depending on the circumstances and your willingness to engage in recovery.
    - *Second relapse:* You will be immediately removed from the program—no exceptions. However, you are still required to return to NGU to participate in Intensive Outpatient Programming (IOP) and individual counseling sessions.
- Violation of Rules: Breaking program rules may result in the loss of passes, loss of visiting privileges, additional counseling, or program termination.

Program Expectations

Participants of the Reentry Program are expected to participate fully in the program, which is designed to support their successful reintegration into society. The following are the core program components that outline the expectations of participants:

24/7 Supervision and Accountability:

- The reentry program provides supervised, structured housing with clearly defined rules and expectations. Adherence to these rules and expectations is required.
- Regular check-ins are required, along with mandatory "coding in" to the house, adherence to a curfew, and camera surveillance to ensure accountability and safety.
- Participants must comply with urinalysis testing if drug or alcohol use is suspected.
- Importantly, all activities (aside from employment) are done together. This is a "we" program and, therefore, we stand stronger together.

Employment and Workforce Development:

- Participants will engage in resume building, interview participation, and skills training through Metropolitan Community College's 180 Reentry Assistance Program (180 RAP).
- Participants are expected to obtain employment.
- If employment has not been secured, participants are expected to participate in volunteer work at Heart Ministry to gain work experience and contribute to the community.

Therapy, Recovery, Life Skills, and Community Reintegration:

- Dialectical Behavior Therapy (DBT) group counseling is required approximately three times per week from 6:00 to 7:00pm to support emotional regulation and interpersonal effectiveness.
- Intensive Outpatient Program (IOP) participation is required two times per week from 6:00 to 8:30pm to support mental health and substance use treatment.
- Alcoholics Anonymous (AA) and Narcotics Anonymous (NA) meetings are required two to four times per week to support sobriety.
- Participants are required to attend weekly financial literacy meetings to develop important budgeting and money management skills (Tuesday).
- On Fridays/Saturdays, participants must partake in prosocial group activities, such as attending University of Nebraska Omaha and Creighton sporting events, visiting the Hot Shops Art Center, or enjoying outdoor activities like Beaver Lake.
- Church attendance at Brookside Church on Sunday mornings (10:00am to 12:00pm) is required to help participants rebuild spiritual and/or social networks.
- Visitation events with approved family and friends are held on Sundays from 1:00pm to 6:00pm to encourage family reintegration. Participants are required to be in attendance.
- Sponsor Night takes place on Sundays from 6:00pm to 9:00pm to build supportive relationships with sponsors. During this time, sponsors can pick up participants from their reentry house.
- Individualized one-on-one therapy with a Licensed Independent Mental Health Practitioner (LIMHP) is available as needed.
- Volunteer work is required at community events, as applicable.
- Peer mentorship is offered to support participants in their transition back into the community and develop positive relationships.

Print Name (First, Middle, Last): _____

Signature: _____ **Date:** _____/_____/_____

NGU Transitional Living Orientation Checklist:

Print Name (First, Middle, Last): _____

Basic Necessities:

- Obtain clothes/shoes and hygiene products: ☐ Completed
    - Date obtained: _____/_____/_____
    - Notes: _____
- Obtain Uber transportation allowance: ☐ Completed ☐ N/A
    - Date obtained: _____/_____/_____
    - Notes: _____

Identification and Documentation:

- Obtain ID or Driver's License: ☐ Completed ☐ N/A
    - Date obtained: _____/_____/_____
    - Notes: _____
- Obtain Birth Certificate, Social Security Number or Card: ☐ Completed ☐ N/A
    - Date obtained: _____/_____/_____
    - Notes: _____

Health and Wellness:

- Obtain EBT (food stamps): ☐ Completed ☐ N/A
    - Date obtained: _____/_____/_____
    - Notes: _____
- Obtain Medicaid/Medicare: ☐ Completed ☐ N/A
    - Date obtained: _____/_____/_____
    - Notes: _____
- Establish a Primary Care Physician at Fontenelle Health Center: ☐ Completed ☐ N/A
    - Date established: _____/_____/_____
    - Primary Care Physician Name: _____
    - Notes: _____

Employment History (start with most recent):

- Employer: _____
    - Position: _____
    - Dates of employment: _____/_____/_____ to _____/_____/_____
- Employer: _____
    - Position: _____
    - Dates of employment: _____/_____/_____ to _____/_____/_____
- Employer: _____
    - Position: _____
    - Dates of employment: _____/_____/_____ to _____/_____/_____
- Employer: _____
    - Position: _____
    - Dates of employment: _____/_____/_____ to _____/_____/_____

Employment:

- Type of job desired? _____

  _____
- Explain to participant when and how the job search begins/works: ☐ Completed
    - Date explained: _____/_____/_____
    - Notes: _____
- Obtain employment: ☐ Completed
    - Date obtained: _____/_____/_____
    - Employer: _____
    - Position: _____
    - Starting wage: _____

Financials:

- Open savings/checking account at Centris Financial Credit Union: ☐ Completed ☐ N/A
    - Date opened: _____/_____/_____
    - Notes: _____

Technology and Communication:

- Provide Cellphone, Case, and Screen Protector: ☐ Completed ☐ N/A
    - Date provided: _____/_____/_____
    - Notes: _____
    - Explain to participant what is provided by NGU (e.g., 1 month paid service)

Family and Social Connections:

- Obtain prison visitor approved list: ☐ Completed
    - Date obtained: _____/_____/_____
- List individuals on approved visitor list:
    - Name: _____
        - Relationship: _____
    - Name: _____
        - Relationship: _____
    - Name: _____
        - Relationship: _____
    - Name: _____
        - Relationship: _____
    - Name: _____
        - Relationship: _____
    - Name: _____
        - Relationship: _____

Parole/Probation:

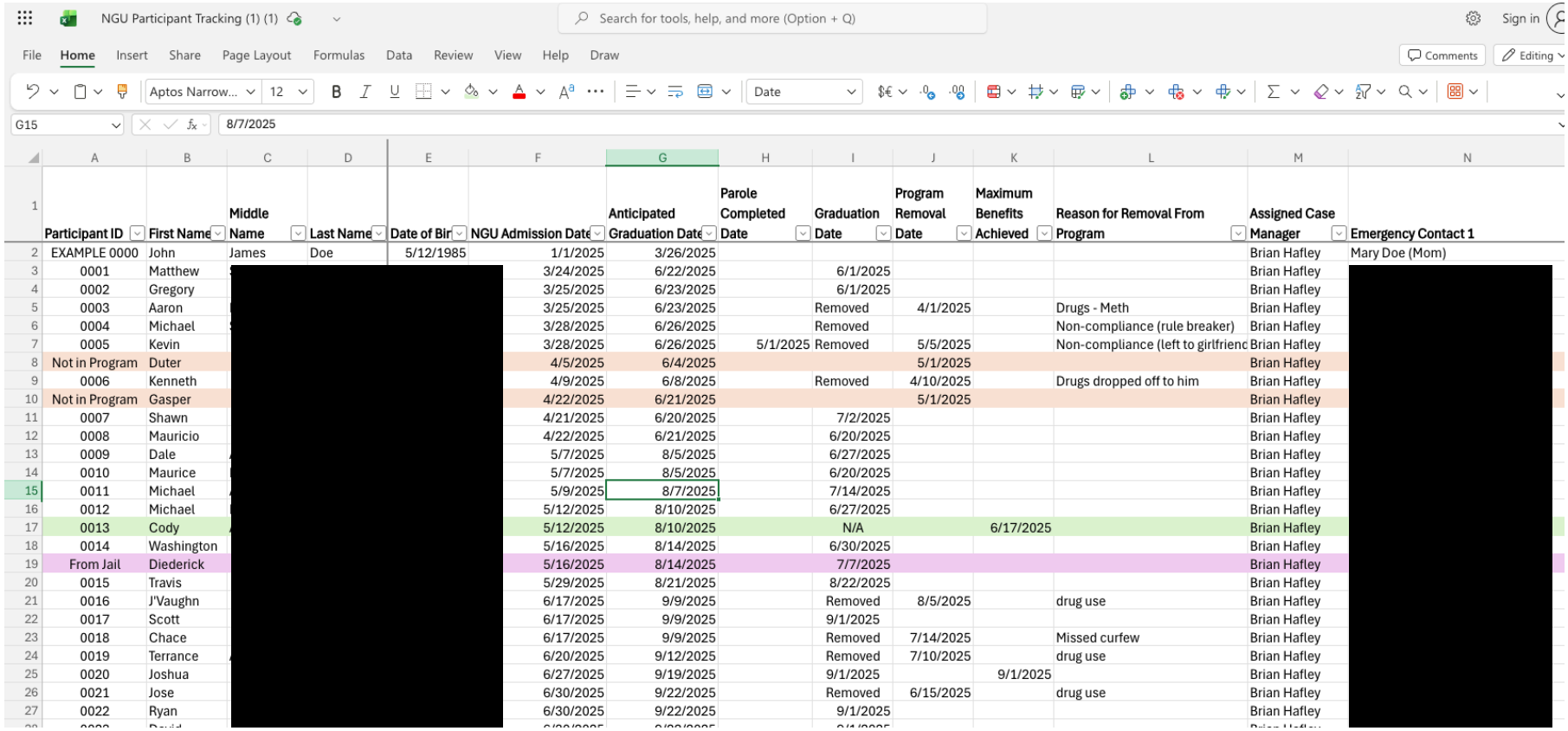
- Parole/Probation Officer name: _____
- Parole/Probation Officer telephone number: _____
- Verify contact with parole/probation officer: ☐ Yes ☐ No
    - Date of last contact: _____/_____/_____
    - Next schedule contact: _____/_____/_____
    - Notes: _____

      _____

Emergency Telephone Numbers (family members or friends):

Name and Address	Relationship	Telephone Number
4.		
5.		
6.		

Appendix G. Participant Tracking Template



NGU Participant Tracking (1) (1)

Search for tools, help, and more (Option + Q)

Sign in

File Home Insert Share Page Layout Formulas Data Review View Help Draw

Comments Editing

Aptos Narrow... 12 Date

G15 8/7/2025

	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	I	J	K	L	M	N
1	Participant ID	First Name	Middle Name	Last Name	Date of Bir	NGU Admission Date	Anticipated Graduation Date	Parole Completed Date	Graduation Date	Program Removal Date	Maximum Benefits Achieved	Reason for Removal From Program	Assigned Case Manager	Emergency Contact 1
2	EXAMPLE 0000	John	James	Doe	5/12/1985	1/1/2025	3/26/2025						Brian Hafley	Mary Doe (Mom)
3	0001	Matthew	[redacted]			3/24/2025	6/22/2025		6/1/2025				Brian Hafley	[redacted]
4	0002	Gregory				3/25/2025	6/23/2025		6/1/2025				Brian Hafley	
5	0003	Aaron				3/25/2025	6/23/2025		Removed	4/1/2025		Drugs - Meth	Brian Hafley	
6	0004	Michael				3/28/2025	6/26/2025		Removed			Non-compliance (rule breaker)	Brian Hafley	
7	0005	Kevin				3/28/2025	6/26/2025	5/1/2025	Removed	5/5/2025		Non-compliance (left to girlfriend	Brian Hafley	
8	Not in Program	Duter				4/5/2025	6/4/2025			5/1/2025			Brian Hafley	
9	0006	Kenneth				4/9/2025	6/8/2025		Removed	4/10/2025		Drugs dropped off to him	Brian Hafley	
10	Not in Program	Gasper				4/22/2025	6/21/2025			5/1/2025			Brian Hafley	
11	0007	Shawn				4/21/2025	6/20/2025		7/2/2025				Brian Hafley	
12	0008	Mauricio				4/22/2025	6/21/2025		6/20/2025				Brian Hafley	
13	0009	Dale				5/7/2025	8/5/2025		6/27/2025				Brian Hafley	
14	0010	Maurice				5/7/2025	8/5/2025		6/20/2025				Brian Hafley	
15	0011	Michael				5/9/2025	8/7/2025		7/14/2025				Brian Hafley	
16	0012	Michael				5/12/2025	8/10/2025		6/27/2025				Brian Hafley	
17	0013	Cody				5/12/2025	8/10/2025		N/A		6/17/2025		Brian Hafley	
18	0014	Washington				5/16/2025	8/14/2025		6/30/2025				Brian Hafley	
19	From Jail	Diederick				5/16/2025	8/14/2025		7/7/2025				Brian Hafley	
20	0015	Travis				5/29/2025	8/21/2025		8/22/2025				Brian Hafley	
21	0016	J'Vaughn				6/17/2025	9/9/2025		Removed	8/5/2025		drug use	Brian Hafley	
22	0017	Scott				6/17/2025	9/9/2025		9/1/2025				Brian Hafley	
23	0018	Chace				6/17/2025	9/9/2025		Removed	7/14/2025		Missed curfew	Brian Hafley	
24	0019	Terrance				6/20/2025	9/12/2025		Removed	7/10/2025		drug use	Brian Hafley	
25	0020	Joshua				6/27/2025	9/19/2025		9/1/2025		9/1/2025		Brian Hafley	
26	0021	Jose				6/30/2025	9/22/2025		Removed	6/15/2025		drug use	Brian Hafley	
27	0022	Ryan				6/30/2025	9/22/2025		9/1/2025				Brian Hafley	

Appendix H. DBT Programming Guide and Worksheets - Overview

Never Give Up Transitional Living

Dialectical Behavior Therapy Programming Guide

Dialectical Behavior Therapy (DBT) is a structured therapy that focuses on teaching four core skills—mindfulness, acceptance and distress tolerance, emotional regulation, and interpersonal effectiveness—to help you create a good life for yourself. Overall, DBT incorporates various skills to help individuals manage emotions and improve interpersonal relationships.

DBT is a type of Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (CBT). CBT focuses on helping people change unhelpful thought patterns. DBT takes those CBT ideas or challenging unhelpful thought patterns, but also adds additional elements like mindfulness, acceptance and distress tolerance, and interpersonal skills to give you more tools for dealing with hard situations.

Mindfulness Exercises

1. STOP Skill
2. Wise Mind
3. Mental Noting

Distress Tolerance Exercises

1. Cost Benefit Analysis
2. Willingness vs. Willfulness
3. Radical Acceptance

Emotion Regulation Exercises

1. Recognize Your Emotions
2. Check the Facts
3. Balancing Emotional Urges

Interpersonal Effectiveness Exercises

1. Communication Styles
2. DEARMAN
3. Barriers to Interpersonal Effectiveness

Appendix I. Program Flyer

a Good Turn Labor Inc. organization

NEVER GIVE UP TRANSITIONAL LIVING

NGU
TRANSITIONAL LIVING
"NEVER GIVE UP"

THE FOUNDER:

- Shane Reilly spent over 17 years in prison across 5 sentences
- His vision of the program came from his personal lived experience

THE TEAM:

- Every employee has graduated from the program

NGU TRANSITIONAL LIVING:

- Unique, out-of-the-box approach
- Substance abuse treatment
- Peer-driven approach
- 12-weeks/84 days
- Structured transitional housing
- Employment and workforce development
- Therapy and life skills development
- Community network redevelopment
- Support services





402-359-7404
ngutlomaha@gmail.com
nevergiveupomaha.org

Help Us
Change Lives:

Appendix J. Program Brochure

Our Purpose

The Reentry Challenge

Each year, about 2,000 people are released from Nebraska state prisons. But reentering society isn't easy. Returning citizens face overlapping barriers—housing instability, employment discrimination, addiction, untreated mental health concerns, stigma, criminal thinking, and fractured family ties. Without meaningful support, many return to the system they just left.

The NGU Solution

The Never Give Up (NGU) Transitional Living Program is a sober, structured reentry program operated by the nonprofit Good Turn Labor. We help formerly incarcerated individuals move toward independent living with support, stability, and accountability.

Who We Serve

NGU supports men returning from prison who:

1. Are approved for community supervision or parole
2. Are motivated to participate in a structured, sober reentry program
3. Have completed the application, phone interview, and background review*

*Individuals with a history of sex offense convictions are not eligible for the program

Meet The Team



Shane Reilly, MS
Program Director & Development Director



Julie Micek, LIMHP
Executive Director & Health Support and Counseling Specialist



Jimmy King
Assistant Program Director & Resident Manager



Brian Hafley
Case Manager

+ Peer Support Specialists

Get in Touch

- www.nevergiveupomaha.org
- ngutlomaha@gmail.com
- (402) 359 7404
- Omaha, Nebraska

Never Give Up

Never Give Up
Transitional Living



Testimonials

"Be ready for a life changing experience. This program its very motivating. It's very uplifting...What you put into this program is what you're gonna get out of it. There's great qualities in the program that enabled me to become self-sufficient, maintain good employment, work on my credit, and just become an all-around productive member of society and a good person."

-Jason G., Never Give Up Program Participant

"I've had the opportunity to work with numerous transitional living programs...NGU stands out as a model of excellence. Shane's commitment to structured support, accountability, and genuine care creates real opportunities for lasting change."

-Brian Bencker, Assistant Program Director of NDCS Community Supervision Service

"It is great to see [the men] come in and start their financial journey with us...Some of them have been able to do things they hadn't done before such as purchase a car from a dealership or...a home. It is the confidence that comes from being able to accomplish goals in a way they maybe hadn't before that makes this partnership special to all of us!"

-Yvonne, Financial Sales Manager, Centris Bank

HELP US CHANGE LIVES

Donate to Never Give Up through the 501(c)(3) organization, Good Turn Labor, LLC.

Our Services

Housing & Basic Needs
Stable housing and essentials—food, clothing, transport, and a phone—so participants can rebuild, not just survive.

Intensive Outpatient Programming (IOP)
Structured in-house groups for relapse prevention, coping, and recovery.

Dialectical Behavior Therapy
Evidence-based treatment for managing emotions, stress, and relationships.

Individual Counseling
Private counseling for trauma, mental health, addiction, and growth.

Alcoholics & Narcotics Anonymous
Peer-led 12-step groups providing support, accountability, and a sober community.

Employment Support
Job search assistance, skill building, and maintaining work.

Community & Family
Prosocial outings and family visits to rebuild trust and strengthen social bonds.

Financial Literacy Classes
Guidance in budgeting, saving, credit management, and financial stability.

ID & Benefits Assistance
Help securing ID, SSN, EBT, and Medicaid.

Faith-Based Support
Church attendance, mentorship, and faith-based volunteering.

NGU
TRANSITIONAL LIVING
"NEVER GIVE UP"

Our Goal

To reduce recidivism and support long lasting integration by building personal accountability, strengthening community connections, and ensuring access to the tools people need to succeed.

Why We're Unique

- **Lived Experience:** Every man on our team beat prison—and now leads others to freedom
- **Unshakeable Belief:** We never give up on you
- **Real Support, Real Change:** More than a place to stay, NGU helps rebuild lives
- **Creative Solutions:** Fresh ideas for lasting change



Appendix K. Presentation (front slide)



Appendix L. Chapter Under Review

Never Give Up: Strengthening Reentry Through Research and Practice Collaboration

Taylor A. Gonzales[1]
Jennifer J. Tostlebe[1]
Shane Reilly[2]

[1] University of Nebraska Omaha, School of Criminology and Criminal Justice
[2] Never Give Up Transitional Living, Omaha, NE

Collaborating Across Differences in Sentencing and Corrections: Process and Outcomes
DCS Handbook on Corrections and Sentencing, Volume 11
Editors: Drs. Ebony Ruhland, Julie Baldwin, Jodi Lane, and Ashley Nellis

"To say I was being set up to fail is being gracious… *What I needed was someone who had been to prison and was successfully navigating reentry to mentor me*. I needed someone to tell me that applying for a job, for housing, or for a loan was different for folks with a felony conviction. Having someone tell me that being a father, a son, and even a brother was totally different after prison would have made an enormous difference in my life… Creating pathways to successful reentry is just as incumbent upon the community as the individual, as transformation and redemption is expected, if not demanded, from formerly incarcerated individuals."
–Lewis Conway, 2,095 days in Texas prisons and 4,012 days on parole (2020, emphasis added)

Each year, more than 400,000 incarcerated individuals are released from U.S. state and federal prisons (Carson & Kluckow, 2023). This transition—commonly referred to as "prisoner reentry" (Mears & Cochran, 2015; Travis, 2005)—is complex, and while scholars and practitioners continue to debate its precise definition, there is broad agreement that everything about the prison and post-prison experiences are inextricably linked and contribute to reentry success (Petersilia, 2004; Visher & Travis, 2003). Despite the fact that 95 percent of people in prison will eventually be released (Hugh & James, 2002), the criminal justice system and society-at-large remains ill-equipped to support their return. Indeed, studies consistently show that the majority of formerly incarcerated individuals struggle to reintegrate into society (e.g., Ortiz & Jackey, 2019; Western, 2018). Approximately 80% of people released are rearrested within nine years (Alper et al., 2018) and nearly half return to prison within five years (Durose & Antenangeli, 2021; although see Bushway & Denver, 2025).

Reentry is often described by those experiencing it as a "second sentence" or an "invisible punishment"—a period marked not by freedom, but by isolation, instability, and systemic exclusion (Miller, 2021; Travis, 2005). Individuals returning home must navigate overlapping barriers that are commonly referred to as "collateral consequences" of incarceration: housing insecurity, employment discrimination, stigma, untreated mental health concerns, alcohol and/or drug addiction, criminal mindset, and fractured family ties (e.g., Buck et al., 2022; Harding et al., 2019; Mears & Cochran, 2015; Meitl, 2021; Western et al., 2015). The toll of

these barriers can be overwhelming and—without meaningful support—many people cycle back into the very system they just exited (Berg & Huebner, 2011; Comfort & Maruna, 2024).

Transitional housing facilities offer one approach to disrupting this cycle. These programs aim to provide stable housing and supportive services in the months following release from incarceration (Beha, 1977; Fontaine et al., 2012). In this chapter we focus on one type of transitional housing: *transitional living programs*—a distinction we make below. While models vary in terms of size, length, and design, transitional living programs often include peer mentorship, case management, accountability structures, and connections to employment or treatment. Ideally, they serve as a bridge between structured institutional supervision and independent community living. But, we believe, these programs can only succeed when they are grounded in the real-world needs of their participants and when their structures are deeply responsive, flexible, and informed by both rigorous research and the lived experiences of those who have been through the criminal justice system.

This is where researcher-practitioner partnerships (RPPs) play an informative role. RPPs are collaborative relationships between researchers and practitioners aimed at co-producing knowledge, improving service delivery, and informing policy or practice (Grieco et al., 2014; Murray et al., 2015). Unlike traditional research approaches, which extract information for knowledge production (Blomberg, 2019), RPPs are built on shared goals, mutual respect, and the belief that both research and real-world experience are essential sources of insight. In the context of reentry, these partnerships hold promise (e.g., Rudes et al., 2014; Taxman et al., 2003).

Yet, while both RPPs and transitional housing have gained attention in recent years (e.g., Berghuis, 2018; Jonson & Cullen, 2015; Saunders et al., 2020; Wong et al., 2025), far less has been written about transitional living programs, specifically, and how these programs and RPPs

intersect—particularly when the program director is also someone with lived experience. Instead, most existing literature on RPPs focuses on institutional collaborations in education, healthcare, or policing (Alpert et al., 2013; Sjölund et al., 2023; Zych et al., 2020). Similarly, reentry program evaluations often rely on top-down research approaches that may overlook the insights of those doing the day-to-day work (Miller & Miller, 2015). What is missing are ground-level accounts of how community-led reentry programs and academic partners can build relationships, co-generate knowledge, and navigate the challenges of equity-driven collaboration.

This chapter addresses this gap by examining the partnership between Never Give Up (NGU) Transitional Living, a sober, transitional, peer-support intervention program in Omaha, Nebraska, and academic researchers. Co-authored by NGU's founder and director (Reilly)—who was formerly incarcerated—and two researchers (Gonzales and Tostlebe), this chapter traces how our partnership evolved to support program development, long-term sustainability, goals of outward expansion, and future evaluation. We begin by discussing the broader reentry landscape and highlight the role of transitional housing facilities, with a specific focus on transitional living programs. Second, we examine relevant lessons from the RPP literature. From there, we detail Reilly's story and NGU. Fourth, we turn to the partnership itself including how it formed; early organizational instability challenges; our collaboration; and future directions. With the third author bringing invaluable insights as a program director, someone with lived experience, and holding a master's degree, the first and second authors have focused on supporting NGU's development through standardization, evidence-based practices, and long-term sustainability planning. Finally, we provide ten lessons learned through our collaboration. In doing so, we offer a case study in collaborative partnerships—and illuminate the challenges, lessons, and transformative potential of RPPs that center the voices of formerly incarcerated individuals.

The Reentry Experience

"Reentry" refers to the *process* through which individuals return to the community following a period of incarceration (Mears & Cochran, 2015). While criminal justice policy often treats reentry as a discrete stage in the criminal justice system (i.e., crime → arrest → conviction → incarceration → *reentry*), it is best understood not as a singular event—such as the moment of release or first evening home—but as an extended, non-linear transition beginning during incarceration and continuing well beyond release (Petersilia, 2003; Travis, 2005; Visher & Travis, 2003). It is shaped by individual circumstances, systematic conditions, and the social and cultural environment. Because of this, reentry is messy, uncertain, and rarely complete.

When the third author asked participants in his transitional living program to describe reentry, they overwhelmingly used words like "scary," "overwhelming," and "stressful." But they also spoke of a combination of relief and uncertainty, saying things like "I'm satisfied with finally being out," "how long until I mess up again?," and "what direction do I even take?" Others expressed hope and determination, describing themselves as "more prepared after the second time," "having goals and dreams," and "wanting support." These reflections tie into a central finding in the reentry literature: there is substantial variation in reentry experiences (Huebner & Berg, 2011; Visher & Travis, 2003). People differ not only in if and when they return to custody, but in how they find housing or employment, reintegrate into family and friend networks, manage health needs, and navigate supervision.

For many, the first hours and days after release are experienced as a mix of euphoria and psychological disorientation (Haynes, 2014). Freedom can be exhilarating—sensory overload, new technology, open air, hot food, companionship. But this feeling often, and sometimes quickly, gives way to perplexity and emotional whiplash—the world has changed; time has not

stood still; and expectations from parole officers, family and friends, and even oneself arrive fast and hard. Being “free” is not the same as being supported. The abrupt shift from hyper-regulated prison life to loosely structured community life—with little-to-no preparation or support—can trigger panic, social withdrawal, or relapse (Pettus, 2023; Western, 2018). Indeed, some individuals describe reentry as more psychologically taxing than incarceration itself (Pettus-Davis & Kennedy, 2019). This can be even more true if the individual experienced primary or secondary victimization during incarceration (Novisky & Peralta, 2020).

Research consistently shows that this abrupt shift—the days, weeks, and months immediately following release—is the most critical time period. In the majority of states, people leaving prison are released with little more than the clothing on their back, a token amount of money, a bus ticket, and—if applicable—the name and address of their parole officer and a list of supervision conditions. As one person put it: “They kick guys out of here with nothing, they go out there, they don’t know what to do, they sell drugs, rob someone, or just come back to jail… (La Vigne et al., 2004, p. 50). Indeed, formerly incarcerated individuals face the highest risk of arrest within six months of release from prison (Huebner & Berg, 2011), and they are more likely to die—often from drug overdose—within the first two weeks (Binswanger et al., 2007).

These vulnerabilities are compounded by structural and systematic instability. Stable housing is often seen as the foundation of successful reintegration, yet it remains elusive for many people returning to prison. Formerly incarcerated individuals face financial insecurity, legal housing restrictions, and landlord discrimination (Leasure, 2019; Muñoz-Jones & Widra, 2023). Transitional housing options are in short supply, and waitlists can stretch for weeks or months. As a result, many return to the same disadvantaged communities they left (Morenoff & Harding, 2014), which increases their risk of recidivism (Kirk, 2009).

Finding meaningful work can also feel like an uphill battle. While employment is theoretically described as a source of informal social control that promotes desistance from crime (Sampson & Laub, 1993), a criminal record significantly hinders access to stable jobs. Employers frequently reject applicants with records (Page, 2003), although recent research has highlighted how specific credentials or qualifications can supersede this cost by signaling employability and reliability (Lindsay, 2022; Santos et al., 2023). Importantly, not just any job will promote success: high-quality, stable jobs—and commitment to the job—is what supports long-term desistance and reintegration (Apel & Horney, 2017; Uggen, 1999; Wadsworth, 2006).

Layered on top of housing and employment barriers are legal restrictions. In many states, people with felony convictions are barred from food stamps, student aid, and certain professional licenses (Bryan, 2023). Reenfranchisement efforts are underway in many states (Uggen et al., 2024), but many people remain restricted from voting (Uggen et al., 2005). These "invisible punishments" extend the reach of the criminal justice system well beyond formal custody.

Even simple logistical tasks, like securing identification or getting to an appointment, can further complicate the process. Many individuals leave prison without essential forms of identification (La Vigne et al., 2004), which makes it difficult to verify their identity, age, citizenship; obtain prosocial employment; open a bank account; or apply for government benefits. Also, many return home with few financial resources (La Vigne et al., 2004). These financial constraints can make basic needs difficult to meet—including transportation. Public transit, when available, is often unreliable or prohibitively expensive (Nordberg et al., 2021), leading to missed parole meetings, job shifts, and mandatory treatment or counseling sessions.

Prison often provides the first consistent access to physical, mental, and substance use health care (Tostlebe & Muñoz-Jones, 2025; Wildeman & Wang, 2017; although see Wang &

Widra, 2024). But release from prison may mark the end of reliable access, as research shows health care becomes severely limited in the community (Mallik-Kane & Visher, 2008). And waitlists for substance use treatment can stretch for months. Even when services exist, they may be unaffordable, geographically distant, or full (Gunnison & Helfgott, 2017). As the third author argues, this is not a secondary concern—it is foundational. Without adequate treatment for chronic health conditions, mental illness, or addiction, everything else begins to unravel—people cannot sustain employment, maintain housing, or meet the basic demands of supervision.

Community supervision can compound instability, with strict conditions that are often difficult to meet under real-world constraints. Curfews, random drug testing, employment verification, and mandatory programming are strictly enforced (Petersilia, 2003). Even minor violations can trigger revocation. These conditions are often applied uniformly, with little regard for personal circumstances or the availability of services. During COVID-19, some agencies adopted virtual supervision and more flexible policies, revealing that relational, trust-based virtual models can be effective (Schwalbe & Koetzle, 2021; Viglione et al., 2020). Still, the dominant experience remains one of surveillance and exclusion (Wacquant, 2001).

The challenges of reentry may be further impeded by the persistence of a criminal mindset, criminal networks, or deep ties to criminogenic subcultures. For example, while gang membership has been identified as playing a role in facilitating successful reentry (Lopez-Aguado, 2018), it may garner enhanced monitoring from criminal justice authorities based on gang labeling and continue to shape identities and allegiances, creating pressure to maintain prior behaviors and impeding reintegration (Pyrooz et al., 2021; Lopez-Aguado, 2018; Scott, 2004).

Finally, external stigma cuts across all domains. Despite having served their time, a criminal record functions as a social mark, shaping how others perceive and treat you

(Braithwaite, 1989; Denver et al., 2017; 2024). Returning citizens are often viewed as dangerous, dishonest, or unreliable. For people of color, these assumptions intersect with long-embedded racial stereotypes, reinforcing multiple layers of marginalization (Williams et al., 2019). Stigma can lead to family rejection, social isolation, and a loss of confidence—undermining even the most motivated efforts to rebuild (Turney et al., 2013).

Despite this mountain of barriers, what is often lost in public narratives is that most people *want* to succeed. Many leave prison determined to do better—to stay sober, find steady work, reconnect with their families, and avoid returning to crime (Ward & Stewart, 2003). The desistance literatures have shown this is possible (for reviews, see Bersani & Doherty, 2018; Nguyen & Loughran, 2018). Maruna (2001) found that people who constructed a "redemption script," a narrative that reframed their past into a source of strength and positioned themself as capable of change and contribution, were often the ones actively desisting from crime. This type of internal transformation plays a powerful role in the reentry process. But the redemption script often cannot thrive in isolation. When hope collides with inaccessible resources and exclusion, it can give way to frustration and despair, leading people back toward a life of crime and addiction.

Importantly, while some individuals return home to strained or fragmented relationships with support networks (e.g., Comfort, 2008; Doyle et al., 2024; Western et al., 2015), reentry is not always navigated alone. Some are fortunate to land in environments that offer structure, support, and guidance immediately following release. One mechanism intentionally designed with this purpose in mind are transitional housing facilities (Abadinsky, 1987). Depending on their structure, these facilities offer far more than temporary shelters; they can serve as stabilizing spaces that offer structure, guidance and support, accountability, human connection, and opportunity. Next, we examine the landscape of transitional housing options in the U.S.

Prisoner Transitional Housing Facilities

Different types of transitional housing facilities are often described interchangeably. But we believe there are important distinctions in terms of structure, oversight, and intended population (see Table 1). *Halfway houses* generally refer to structured, community-based housing for individuals under correctional supervision and are focused on compliance with legal conditions and reducing recidivism through surveillance, curfews, and mandatory drug testing (Hamilton & Campbell, 2014; Wong et al., 2025). *Oxford Houses* are a nationwide network of peer-run sober living homes for individuals in recovery (Jason & Ferrari, 2010; Jason et al., 2001). While not professionally staffed, they emphasize accountability, self-governance, and a commitment to sobriety; however, there are no programmatic elements resulting in little-to-no meaningful structure for those coming out of prison. *Residential Reentry Centers* (RRCs) are federally funded and regulated programs used by the Bureau of Prisons to house individuals nearing the end of their sentence (Ellis & Henderson, 2017; Russo et al., 2023). These centers have strict requirements around curfew, employment, and supervision.

Also falling under the umbrella of transitional housing are *transitional living programs*, which offer structured residential environments that combine safe housing with case management and wraparound services (e.g., Steel & Minardi, n.d.). They are typically operated by nonprofits or community organizations, are designed to promote stability, and serve as a foundation for rebuilding a life after incarceration, with meaningful, observable, and measurable elements present from day one. Program durations typically range from 60 to 180 days and often culminate in a formal graduation. For many, this marks the first time they have lived in a stable, structured, and supportive environment in the community. And, in some programs, participants may transition into step-up housing for up to one year after completing the core program.

Table 1 here

With this typology in mind, the remainder of this chapter focuses specifically on transitional living programs for individuals recently released from prison. To better understand the programs offered across the U.S., we began by drawing on the third author's knowledge and familiarity with transitional living programs. Building on this foundation, we next conducted a systematic search to identify other current offerings in the United States. This process entailed using Google to search for the phrases: *"prisoner residential reentry program in [state],"* *"parolee residential reentry programs in [state],"* and "*prisoner halfway houses in [state]*." Next, we searched Google Scholar for the phases: *"prisoner transitional living evaluations"* and *"residential reentry program evaluations."* After identifying articles, we reviewed them and their reference lists for any mention or link to specific programs. When programs were identified, we navigated to their websites to determine if the program matched our understanding of transitional living programs (i.e., structured housing in the community for people leaving prison that incorporated case management and reentry-related services). For those that matched our definition, we collected information on the program and any empirical evaluations.

Importantly, despite the wide range of program types and local variations, the search proved difficult in that it was challenging to identify comprehensive, up-to-date information; program websites, when in existence, varied widely in quality and availability of information. This highlights the under-documented nature of this service landscape. Some organizations provided robust descriptions of eligibility criteria, program philosophy, and services (e.g., Talbert House Inc., Turning Point of Central California), while others had little-to-no online presence.

Table 2 provides an overview of the 14 transitional living programs—designed for people reentering society post incarceration—we identified through this process. These programs vary

in geographies, program length (*mean*=123.7 days ; *SD*=54.23; *min*=60 days, *max*=no limit), and program emphasis.[1] However, most adopt a holistic model that reflects the interdependence of housing, health, and opportunity. Many had common services including employment support (92.9%), case management (78.6%), behavioral health services (57.1%), sober living (50%), and substance abuse counseling (35.7%).

Many of these programs are deeply embedded in their local reentry ecosystems and have earned reputations for effective, compassionate care. For example, some participants have stated:

> "[I] was welcomed by an accepting and non-judgemental staff that were eager to be of assistance…I recommend their services to the clients as well as there loved ones - all of whom will be better educated in this road to reentry." (Golden Rule ReEntry)

> "Being at Sponsors really did help me transition out of prison life and back into our community – I wouldn't have stayed out of prison without Sponsors. A lot of people that are incarcerated just give up on themselves. Somehow, I did not. Since getting out of prison I have accomplished things and I know I can work and I can continue to communicate and accomplish more. Prison does not offer rehabilitation, but Sponsors does and for that I am so grateful." (Sponsors Inc.)

However, only one of the 14 (7.1%) identified programs have been evaluated. Willison et al. (2010) conducted a four-year quasi-experimental evaluation of Ridge House, a residential reentry program in Nevada. The evaluation compared participants of the program (*n*=156) to a comparison group who were accepted but did not participate (*n*=461). The study found that simply participating in Ridge House was not significantly associated with reductions in overall rearrest rates, with the exception of society arrests. However, program *completers* had a 16% lower probability of being rearrested and a lower incidence of property and person crimes compared to the comparison group. These findings suggest that while mere participation may not be sufficient, successful program completion is linked to reduced recidivism.[2]

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[1] Statistics based on available information. Mean calculation based on minimum values if program had a range.
[2] Although Sponsors Inc. has received academic attention, existing studies focus on proximal outcomes rather than formal evaluations of effectiveness (e.g., Kjellstrand et al., 2023a; Kjellstrand et al., 2023b).

While evaluation remains limited, existing evidence—along with community testimony—suggests that these programs can reduce recidivism, improve housing stability, and support long-term wellbeing. Importantly, success is defined not only by avoiding rearrest or reincarceration, but holistically, including sustained employment, sobriety, family and community reconnection, and development of a prosocial identity (Fahmy & Mitchell, 2022).

Table 2 here

The challenge ahead lies in improving evaluation, expanding access, and ensuring sustainable funding for programs *that work holistically*. Transitional living programs are not a silver bullet—but they are among the most promising tools we have to support meaningful second chances. Their success, however, depends on more than just design or funding. We believe that programs thrive when led by directors who care deeply, commit fully, understand the reentry experience firsthand, and prioritize ongoing improvement through a combination of evidence-based practices and insights drawn from lived experience. This is precisely where research-practitioner partnerships can play a transformative role.

Research-Practitioner Partnerships

For programs—like transitional living—to remain effective, adaptable, and sustainable, they must evolve alongside both the communities they serve and evidence-based practices. Research-practitioner partnerships (RPPs) can support this evolution by bridging the gap between research and real-world implementation. RPPs are "long-term mutualistic collaborations between practitioners and researchers that are intentionally organized to investigate problems of practice and solutions for improving…outcomes" (Coburn et al., 2013). Unlike one-off program evaluations, RPPs are built on *bidirectional* collaboration where each partner contributes complementary expertise toward *shared goals* and *mutual benefit* (Cooper et al., 2021).

Within the reentry landscape, practitioners—especially those with lived experience—bring deep knowledge of the barriers faced by clients, service delivery, and community context. They understand what is feasible on the ground and can readily identify the most pressing, unanswered concerns. Researchers, in turn, bring expertise in the broader evidence base, evaluation methods, and data analysis. They help determine what works, for whom, and under what conditions. Together, they co-produce knowledge that is both scientifically sound and practically relevant (e.g., Lane et al., 2004; Wojcik et al., 2021).

RPPs can take many forms. While no single model can fit all settings, most partnerships fall into one or more of three overlapping categories: *inquiry partnerships*, focusing on understanding and investigating problems; *design partnerships*, focusing on developing or improving interventions; and *dissemination partnerships*, focusing on translating and sharing knowledge to diverse audiences to facilitate program improvement and public understanding (see Coburn et al., 2013; Sjölund et al., 2023). Regardless of the structure, the most effective partnerships are those rooted in mutual trust and shared ownership (Klein et al., 2023).

To better understand what makes RPPs successful within criminal justice, Hodgkinson et al. (2024) reviewed 20 years (2000-2020) of published and grey literature from the NIJ online award reporting database and used content analysis to uncover themes. They found 67 unique RPPs—the largest grouping (34%) existed with police agencies. Several factors emerged as central to success including: establish intentions, engage in joint planning, define roles, leverage unique knowledge, invest in ongoing relationship-building, stay adaptable, establish communication protocols, and reciprocate selflessly (pp. 197-200; see also Klein et al., 2023; Sullivan et al., 2017). These characteristics distinguish RPPs from traditional, top-down research models where academic agendas drive the work—frequently at the expense of practitioner needs.

Still, even well-intentioned partnerships face challenges (see Bell et al., 2004; Rudes et al., 2014). Here we review seven commonly identified barriers. First, distrust. Practitioners often view researchers as out of touch and self-serving—reinforcing the "ivory tower" stereotype (den Houting et al., 2022; Rudes et al., 2014). Researchers, in turn, may worry about delayed or restricted data access, program instability, or pressure to alter findings to reflect positively on the program—conditions that run counter to objectivity and transparency.

Second and third, power imbalances and competing priorities. Even in collaborative settings, unequal dynamics can shape whose voice is heard and whose goals take precedence (Bell et al., 2004). Researchers may hold authority through credentials or funding, while practitioners control access and implementation. And each group often operates with different goals: researchers often prioritize theory and rigor while practitioners prioritize service delivery and client needs. Without co-negotiation, one perspective may dominate.

Fourth, communication challenges. Researchers and practitioners often speak different professional languages—especially in a reentry context where one partner has a history of incarceration (but also a master's degree!). Academic jargon and statistical methods can feel inaccessible to frontline staff (Rodriquez, 2018), while practice-based shorthand or—in our case—prison slang may seem imprecise to researchers.

Fifth, mismatched timelines. Academic research can take years, while practitioners often need timely solutions (Rodriguez, 2018). This gap can cause frustration: researchers may find their work rendered obsolete by shifting priorities, and practitioners may see evaluations are too slow to guide real-time decisions. As a result, program leaders may adopt readily available or politically favored practices practices—even if they lack empirical support or alignment with client needs (e.g., in response to school shootings; see Burton et al., 2021; Flannery et al., 2021).

Sixth, organizational instability and turnover. Long-term, trusting collaboration depends on consistent relationships, shared history, and shared understanding—all of which can be disrupted by turnover. In both academic and practitioner settings, staff changes due to burnout, funding shifts, or institutional movement can interrupt communication, slow momentum, deprioritize research goals, or result in loss of project knowledge—or the project altogether.

Finally, implementation barriers. Many programs lack the staff, infrastructure, or resources to act on research, and academic work is often paywalled or written in inaccessible language (Currie, 2007; Tonry, 2010; Uggen & Inderbitizin, 2010). As Petersilia (2008) noted, criminal justice lacks a robust "science of implementation" (p. 350)—a statement that remains true, despite the growth of literature on implementation science (e.g., Taxman, 2025).

Despite their barriers, criminal justice RPPs show promise. These partnerships have supported evidence-based community policing strategies (Hansen et al., 2014) and enhanced offender reentry strategies (e.g., Petersilia, 2008). Still, this work remains in its early stages. A critical next step is building a stronger knowledge base on reentry-focused RPPs, including their initiation, successes, barriers, and how to overcome challenges. As such, we turn to tracing the history of Never Give Up Transitional Living and the RPP between the three authors.

Shane Reilly's Story and Never Give Up Transitional Living

My name is Shane Reilly. I am 59 years old, and I have spent more than half my life battling addiction and incarceration. I was born and raised in Wilmington, Delaware, in a middle-class family. My parents divorced while I was still a child, and I struggled deeply with the emotional fallout. My relationship with my stepfather became so strained that I was sent to a private boarding school. Despite the circumstances, the school provided me with a strong education. I experimented with marijuana and alcohol in high school, but things escalated

quickly after graduation. I moved to Florida to play college soccer, but just days after arriving, I was introduced to cocaine by my Colombian roommate. What started as experimentation quickly turned into obsession. Within two weeks, I was kicked out of school, dropped from the soccer team, and deeply entrenched in using and selling drugs.

From there, my life spiraled. I moved from state to state—Delaware, Florida, Iowa, Nebraska—accumulating criminal charges and convictions. I have been to prison more than 13 times across multiple states and the federal system. At one point, I had 134 criminal entries in Nebraska alone. Addiction controlled every part of my life. I cycled through treatment programs, brief sobriety, relapse, and incarceration. There were moments—especially after a friend of mine took his own life—that nearly broke me entirely.

But even at my lowest, I always had moments of clarity. One of the most transformative moments came in a county jail treatment mod I had not asked to be placed in. One night, I went to an Alcoholics Anonymous meeting—not because I wanted to, but because I could not watch the boxing match from my bunk. I did not plan to speak, but when I passed, the man next to me turned and said: “You know, over in that book it says God will do for you what you can’t do for yourself. But you have to allow it.” That message hit me hard. In that moment, everything I had heard in treatment, Bible college, and life started to click. I realized I had never fully surrendered to any process of change—not spiritually, not practically. I was always trying to control the outcome, always doing what I thought was best. That night was a turning point.

When I got out of jail, I moved into a halfway house. But even there, people were using drugs. Eventually, I found an Oxford House where recovery was more possible. I enrolled at Metropolitan Tech Community College and earned my associate’s in Drug and Alcohol

Counseling. I got clean, stayed clean, and started working at CenterPointe Treatment Center.[3] Later, I earned a bachelor's in Behavioral Science from Bellevue University. I kept working in treatment centers, trying to help others like me, but I felt pulled toward something bigger.

After countless failed reentry attempts of my own, I knew exactly what was missing. Every time I got out of prison, I wanted to change, but I was released into nothing—no support, no structure, no programs that actually addressed the core of what I was facing. I realized that I did not just need a place to stay; I needed a foundation for living differently. One that prioritized sobriety, yes, but also prioritized structure, purpose, and accountability. I pitched a business plan to a mentor and started working to build the program I had needed all those years. Over time, we hired staff who had completed the program—people who truly understood the journey. That's how Never Give Up Transitional Living was born—built on accountability, stability, and hope.

Never Give Up Transitional Living

My (Reilly) vision for Never Give Up (NGU) was deeply informed by my own experiences. I believe criminal thinking is often rooted in addiction, and unless we address that first, nothing else sticks. The federal government reports that nearly 90% of people involved in the justice system have a history of substance use or were under the influence at the time of their crime (NIDA, 2020). If we ignore that and focus only on life skills or jobs, we are setting people up to fail. At NGU, we start with the core issue: addictive thinking. Then, other areas—emotional regulation, accountability, responsibility—can begin to grow. That is NGU's philosophy.

To make that vision real, I knew I needed to be taken seriously in professional spaces. I did not want to just speak from the heart—I also wanted to speak from a place of knowledge. That is why I went back to school to earn my associate's, bachelor's, and master's degrees. I

[3] As of this writing, I (Reilly) have been clean and sober for over eight years.

wanted to sit across the table from people with credentials and be heard—not just as someone with lived experience, but as someone who had done the work to back it up.

That same drive led me to reach out to the University of Nebraska Omaha. I wanted academic partners who could help me refine and evaluate the program—people who could see both the gaps and the potential. At first, I did not think the details they (Gonzales and Tostlebe) focused on were that important. But over time, I began to understand the value of structure, documentation, and evidence-informed practices. Our partnership helped me see NGU not just as a mission, but as a model. We have made changes—some big and some small—that have strengthened the program. This collaboration has shown me that lived experience and academic knowledge do not have to compete—in fact, they are most powerful when they work together.

The program started under a different name than NGU, and, over time, it grew bigger than I ever imagined. We expanded to six houses, employed men (all with lived experience), and served more than 200 participants. I left my original organization and built NGU—something grounded in the lessons I had learned and the kind of accountability I believed in. In March 2025, NGU officially launched. It is a transitional living program for men released from prison who are (1) approved for community supervision or parole, (2) willing and motivated to engage in structured, supportive services, and (c) have completed an application process that includes a phone interview and background screening. To maintain safety for everyone and alignment with the program's structure, men convicted of sexual offenses are not eligible to participate.

The NGU program is 84-days and provides a structured, comprehensive framework designed to promote stability, accountability, and long-term success as individuals transition back into the community. Core components include safe and stable housing, employment readiness and job placement support, therapy designed to help with emotional regulation and

substance use, and connection to family and community networks. Staff work to ensure participants have access to basic needs including identification documents, clothing, and essential services (e.g., medical treatment, transportation), while also fostering an environment of structure and trust through 24/7 supervision and peer mentorship. In doing so, NGU not only fosters personal growth and responsibility, but also helps reduce the likelihood of recidivism.[4]

From my perspective, certain ingredients are essential for a transitional living program to succeed. It starts with leadership—specifically, a program director with *lived experience* who has successfully transitioned after living a life like that of the participants. That foundation builds trust and allows you to relate to the men. But it takes more than just experience. It takes a *support system* (because running a transition living program does take a lot), *resources*, and a *deep passion* to actually help people—and people need to feel your passion. It takes transparency, the ability to wear your emotions on your sleeve, and to make people feel your empathy. It also helps to have some *formal schooling* in a related field, prior experience in the treatment or reentry space, and an *understanding of addiction*—including the reality that this work is not always going to be pretty. A *secondhand leader*, who brings relentless positivity and balance, can also make a huge difference in setting the tone for the house.

Beyond leadership, we have found that *volunteering* and *community engagement* ground our participants in purpose. Through efforts like Heart Ministries, men begin to see their circumstances from a new perspective. We also introduce them to prosocial recreation (e.g., attending hockey games, basketball games, and community events), which helps teach them what it means to enjoy life without the chaos of the streets, smoking dope, or criminal involvement. These small moments build new habits and remind the men of what is possible.

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[4] For more information about the program or to support the program, please visit www.nevergiveupomaha.org.

While a formal evaluation has yet to occur, the impact of NGU is best understood through the voices of the men who have participated. I have heard again and again from participants that NGU feels different—it is not just another program, but a place where people feel seen, challenged, and supported. Their reflections speak to the program's culture of accountability, community, and hope:

> "The program is helpful and a good start for those coming out of prison. Shane really goes out of the way to help people get back on their feet."
>
> "NGU is full of people that hold me accountable and understand where I'm coming from."
>
> "Seeing and hearing from others that have been successful helps me have hope."
>
> "Feeling the aura, love, and community of the men that want to help me—that made me more willing to change."

Since its launch, NGU has admitted 22 men, employees ten men with lived experience, and the work continues to grow, step-by-step.[5] NGU is not perfect. We still have more to learn. However, I know what we are building matters. I am passionate about two things: the Philadelphia Eagles and helping men transform their lives so they never go back to prison. NGU is more than a program—it is a calling. And through our partnership with researchers, we are making it stronger every day.

Building and Navigating a Research-Practitioner Partnership

Phase 1: Recognizing a Need for Research-Practitioner Partnership

The original transitional living program did not begin as a research project. For years, Reilly operated the program based on instinct, experience, and a deep understanding of what people coming out of prison actually needed.[6] Having entered and left prison over ten times, he

[5] Statistics pulled on July 15, 2025.
[6] This chapter was co-written; we refer to ourselves by last name or in third person for clarity.

knew what to felt like to be released into instability—with no housing, limited support, and no clear path forward. He also knew that there was no "one-size-fits-all solution." Each man has a different set of challenges, histories, and goals, and the program needed to reflect that reality.

As Reilly's original program began to grow—from a single house to multiple locations with dozens of residents—he began to recognize a gap: the program was clearly helping people, but it lacked formal documentation, structure, and evaluation. Reilly wanted to ensure that the program he had built from the ground up—through years of trial, error, and more than a little blood, sweat, tears, and hope—could not only be sustained, but strengthened and shared with a national audience to help as many men as possible. He also wanted external evidence of results.

Phase 2: Building Relationships, Trust, and Shared Goals

Grounded in Reilly's realization, our research-practitioner partnership (RPP) began in mid-2023, when Gonzales and Reilly connected at the Omaha 360 Collaborative, a weekly local community meeting in Omaha, Nebraska focused on violence prevention and intervention. Gonzales was attending as part of a university-led grant project, but her presence there was more than a formal obligation. Despite being a first-year doctoral student, she had (and continues to have) a long-standing commitment to community-engaged work, especially within corrections and reentry. The RPP literature emphasizes that when researchers regularly invest time in the community—beyond just collecting data—it helps break down the "ivory-tower" perception, fosters trust, and improves access to lived experience perspectives (e.g., den Houting, 2022). In this case, Gonzales' presence and community engagement opened the door to collaboration.

Reilly, who was already embedded in the reentry and recovery landscape, regularly attended Omaha 360. After one of the meetings, he excitedly approached Gonzales and shared what his transitional living program was doing and why it mattered. He said plainly: "I need to

know if what I am doing is actually working." He was not just looking for validation; he was looking for partnership—someone who could help transform his on-the-ground knowledge into something measurable, credible, and sustainable.

Gonzales brought the conversation to her mentor at the time, who recognized the opportunity and briefly introduced the idea to Tostlebe in late 2023. Soon after, Tostlebe met with Reilly to introduce herself and learn more about the transitional living program—she had not been told much about the meeting and was deep in the trenches of her first semester as a professor. Reilly was bursting with excitement. For him, this meeting was not just about credentials or research strategies (he really did not know what he was getting himself into!)—he wanted to know who Tostlebe was, what she stood for, and whether her values aligned with his.

During their conversation, Tostlebe shared her ongoing work in the Oregon Department of Corrections, where she was the project manager for a study seeking to improve conditions in restrictive housing units (e.g., Labrecque et al., 2021; Tostlebe et al., 2025). She spoke about her belief in using empirical evidence to improve the lives of people impacted by incarceration—not just in theory, but through real, practical change. For Reilly, this was not just talk—it revealed character. Tostlebe's willingness to listen, to speak openly about her motivations, and to show genuine care helped lay the groundwork for a partnership built on trust. These initial conversations also centered on understanding the structure of the transitional living program, the outcomes Reilly hoped to achieve, and the types of support he was seeking. Early goal sharing and honest discussions of expectations helped build the foundation for a collaborative and mutually beneficial RPP (Drawbridge et al., 2018).

Phase 3: From Collaboration to Organizational Instability and Crisis

With the shared goal of supporting the program's long-term success and evaluation, Tostlebe applied for and secured external grant funding through an agency that believed in Reilly's goals—and in Reilly himself. Funding and support for RPPs can be difficult to secure, often contributing to partnerships dissolving prematurely or never getting off the ground at all (Rojek et al., 2012). We have been fortunate to not yet encounter this challenge, allowing the partnership to thrive. As plans for the collaboration took shape, Reilly specifically requested that Gonzales be involved, citing the trust, rapport, and knowledge they had already developed. In response, Tostlebe incorporated funding to support Gonzales' role as a graduate research assistant on the project and became Gonzales' primary mentor. The grant supported the development of a formal research partnership, helped initiate efforts to document and standardize the program, and laid the groundwork for a formal evaluation. While the timeline for the grant application and approval process moved more slowly than Reilly had anticipated—an element of mismatched timelines between the academic and professional worlds (Rodriguez, 2018)—open communication was maintained, and both parties remained committed to the process.

From the outset, our conversations were informal but foundational. Contrary to the academic stereotype (perceived or realized), Gonzales and Tostlebe did not arrive with prewritten surveys, rigid research plans, or predefined evaluation metrics (an intentional decision). While this left Tostlebe (a first-time principal investigator) feeling underprepared, the decision was deliberate with the goal of signaling that the research team was there to listen, not lead, and it laid the groundwork for trust and mutual understanding.

Gonzales and Tostlebe spent their first meetings observing the program and asking *a lot* of questions: What did Reilly want from the partnership? Where did he need support? What

concerns or hopes did he have? In return, Reilly walked them through the day-to-day realities of running the transitional program: how residents were referred and approved, what a typical group counseling session entailed, and what formal or informal procedures guided operations—such as bed assignments, curfew enforcement, and weekly program requirements. This type of operational understanding is essential at the beginning of an RPP (Drawbridge et al., 2018). He also shared areas where the program faced challenges (e.g., tracking residents' progress or managing limited resources). Finally, Reilly shared the moments that brought him the most pride—participants graduating from the program, achieving sobriety, and getting off parole.

These early exchanges were less about research and more about developing a relationship (although Gonzales and Tostlebe did take a lot of notes). We quickly realized that although we come from different personal and professional worlds, we shared core values. We all cared about reducing recidivism. But more than that, we were committed to treating people with dignity by recognizing their worth beyond their criminal records and supporting their autonomy by creating structure that allowed participants to make choices and build independence. We wanted to co-create something that reflected the needs and voices of those who had lived through the system.

Gonzales and Tostlebe continued to progress slowly. They observed program activities including group counseling sessions and participant graduation ceremonies with the goal of better understanding the structure, functioning, and impact of the program. From there, the three authors began collaboratively drafting low-stakes, but meaningful, materials—intake documents and programming materials. These items were already created or being used informally but required refinement to improve standardization and align with evidence-based practices. Gonzales and Tostlebe used the development of these materials as building blocks to show Reilly how academic tools could enhance (rather than replace or change) the program’s overall vision.

The work, however, took an unexpected turn just two months after our formal partnership launched. In March 2023, Reilly and the individual overseeing the transitional living program he was directing had a significant disagreement that ultimately led to a falling out. Reilly departed from the program. The situation created confusion and destabilized the program. Reilly was left without a program to run, while participants remained at the original site under new day-to-day leadership. Confusion regarding parole and admission to the program spread online. One family member posted anonymously on Facebook:

> "Parole hearing tomorrow we need all the luck and prayers we can get!! I'm excited and nervous! And nervous to be excited! I'm ready for this next step already! He has been write up free for almost a year and completed all programming but there's been some issues to the reentry facility he is supposed to go to! Really hope it doesn't affect his parole much unless they tell him he can just come home!..."

Reilly was devastated. He had poured his heart into helping the men in—and coming to—the program. During a partnership meeting, Reilly passionately told Gonzales and Tostlebe:

> "These guys' lives are at stake. There are men sitting in prison thinking they're about to enter a program that's going to help them turn their life around. I told them I would be there for them—and then that program is just gone. It is devastating. We have to get something back up and running, and we have to do it fast. It isn't just necessary—it is urgent and it's personal."

Phase 4: The Launch of Never Give Up Transitional Living

It was in that moment that Never Give Up Transitional Living was dreamed up—and with it, a new phase of our RPP. What began as a joint effort to document and standardize an existing program had transformed into a collaborative effort to develop a new program from the ground up. But the overall mission remained the same: help men successfully and holistically reenter the community after prison. Through Reilly's community connections, the grant was rolled over to support our continuing RPP and the development of a new program.

As we had already begun collaboratively developing standardized materials and procedures—intake forms, basic program descriptions, and evidence-informed procedures—it

was feasible to quickly adapt them to support the new program. These materials became crucial scaffolding in a time of disruption. Through this process, we jointly realized that what could have marked the end of our collaboration instead became a deeper commitment to co-constructing a program that reflected both lived experience and evidence-informed practice. And through that realization, flexibility, adaptability, and trust—all of which had been cultivated and maintained in the earliest phases of our partnership—became the backbone of this phase of our RPP.

Our collaboration went full throttle. Together, Gonzales, Tostlebe, and Reilly formalized key elements of the new NGU program. We developed a detailed program description document that included a situation statement, program goals and objectives, a logic model, target population description, housing model, program structure, program rules and expectations, and outcomes and program success indicators. That document has since gone through five revisions, reflecting our ongoing communication and refinement. Early on, we also collaboratively created:

- A standardized, resident-informed program application form;
- A phone screening interview guide; and
- A rules and expectations document.

Some materials, like the phone screening guide, required close collaboration and negotiation. Reilly emphasized that screening was about intuition—language, tone, what was and was not said. He has years of experience backing up that approach and he was skeptical about applying rigid tools to something so interpersonal. In contrast, Gonzales and Tostlebe emphasized structure, scales, and standardization to ensure equity and reduce potential selection bias.

These conversations revealed deeper questions: How do we balance individual discretion with fairness? What does it mean to "know" someone will succeed? As we were all willing to engage, this has led to an ongoing (and sometimes humorous) debate about how to create a phone screening tool that reflects instinct and equity. Luckily, our trusting and open partnership

has successfully set the stage for us to have these continued conversations, allowing for documents to be revised based on Reilly's needs and our standardization protocol (Lane et al., 2004). At one point, Reilly shared feedback from a conversation he had with the NGU Executive Director, acknowledging that if NGU were to grow—or be implemented elsewhere—his instincts alone would not be enough to sustain the model. Today, the screening tool remains a work in progress, but it now reflects a hybrid model: guided questions rooted in structure paired with space for narrative insight and (small) elements of discretion.

Once the program was up-and-running we continued jointly developing materials:

- A case management orientation and goal-tracking form,
- A participant tracking Excel sheet for internal monitoring and evaluation planning,
- An employee role descriptions document,
- A Dialectical Behavior Therapy (DBT) programming guide and worksheets (revised through negotiation to reflect shared priorities), and
- A public-facing flyer and website.

These materials were not produced in isolation. They emerged from standing meetings, lengthy text threads, candid phone call conversations, and email exchanges. They were grounded in research, reflection, mutual feedback, and a shared vision. For example, Gonzales and Tostlebe developed a "simple" Excel-based participant tracking tool and sent it to the program's case manager. But shortly after it was shared, Reilly quickly called Tostlebe in a panic, saying it was overwhelming. Rather than scraping it or insisting it be used as is, we scheduled an in-person meeting to walk through the tool with the case manager, who realized he had been overthinking it. This exchange was not just about technology. It reflected the spirit of our RPP: recognizing the pressure staff face on the ground, adjusting tools to meet those realities, and co-producing solutions designed to reflect both empirical evidence and practical realities.

Phase 5: Looking Ahead

As NGU has grown, so has our partnership. The team continues to talk regularly, co-produce materials—including this book chapter—and refine tools based on feedback from staff and residents. Recognizing that limited access to key personnel can disrupt an RPP, Gonzales and Tostlebe have also made concerted effort to build relationships beyond Reilly, including with the executive director, assistant program director, case manager, and a member of the non-profit board of directors. These connections help ensure continuity, foster buy-in, and support long-term sustainability of both the program and the partnership (Booker et al., 2019). Future plans include co-presentations to stakeholders to share information about the program and lessons learned from the partnership, an official public-facing program brochure, and a formal evaluation strategy—efforts that continue to reflect our shared commitment to build a program that is evidence-based and rooted in lived experience.

Throughout this collaboration, Gonzales and Tostlebe have played a key role in supporting the development and documentation of NGU. But they remain external partners. Final program design, staffing, and implementation decisions rest squaring with Reilly, his leadership team, and the Good Turn Labor non-profit board that oversees the program. The research team offers guidance grounded in evidence, shares knowledge about promising strategies in reentry and recovery, and helps ensure that NGU's operations remain aligned with its mission. As the program continues to evolve, the RPP remains grounded in the principles that defined it from the start: shared goals, authentic relationships, and a commitment to change lives.

Not every RPP is defined by alignment and ease—but in this case, it has been. Recently, Tostlebe asked Reilly whether he had any concerns at the beginning of the RPP or even now, more than a year in. His response was immediate: "No. We've handled everything together

because we share the same core values—we 'get it'—we need to help these guys stay out of prison." While we have encountered obstacles, we have not experienced conflict or distrust within the partnership itself. That is not accidental. It reflects hard work, steady communication, and a willingness to adapt without arrogance.

Lessons Learned and Best Practices

Even with the relative ease of our partnership, working together has brought up key lessons about what makes our RPP successful, what challenges to expect, and how researchers and practitioners can show up in ways that strengthen, not strain, the RPP. Below, we outline ten key takeaways organized into four pillars: (1) foundations for collaboration, (2) co-creation in practice, (3) embrace real-world complexity, and (4) keep the mission centered.

While we hope these lessons offer guidance, we also want to emphasize that RPPs are not "one-size-fits-all" (Klein et al., 2023). Indeed, our own partnership reflects a unique blend of backgrounds and experience.[7] These differences shape the way we collaborate, learn from one another, and work toward shared goals. As the knowledge base on RPPs continues to grow, we hope our reflections offer practical insights for others embarking on reentry-focused RPPs.

Foundations for Collaboration

The first pillar outlines the essential building blocks of a sustainable RPP. While these practices are foundational, we continue to refine and maintain them.

1 – Start by Listening, Not Leading

It is common for academics to arrive with predetermined goals and project ideas; they are trained to do just that. But in our case, Gonzales and Tostlebe made a deliberate choice to begin

[7] Gonzales is a doctoral student with experience touring prisons and conducting reentry research. Tostlebe is an assistant professor whose perspective is shaped by prison-based research and personal connections to incarceration. Reilly is a transitional living program director with a master's degree whose insight comes from lived experience.

without a fixed agenda, even though it meant tolerating some initial discomfort. That choice proved foundational. It signaled respect, built trust, and created space for Reilly to share his expertise and vision. Furthermore, while all three authors admittedly love to listen to themselves talk, they spent those critical early conversations listening to each other and learning. These choices built the foundation of our partnership as a trusting, mutual learning process.

2 – Treat all Forms of Expertise as Essential

Our RPP brings together academic, operational, and lived expertise. Treating each as equally valid was critical. While part of this was about being respectful, it was also about recognizing that no one perspective can fully capture the complexity of reentry work.

In practice, this meant Gonzales and Tostlebe had to avoid defaulting to academic frameworks and instead integrate Reilly's lived and professional insights. Reilly, in turn, rather instinctually implementing changes, he needed to pause and consult with others (when timing allowed). For example, when a graduate relapsed within days of completing the program and called 911 while high, we had a conversation about how to handle incidents like this moving forward. Tostlebe offered suggestions and together they arrived at a plan that balanced the integrity of the program and the goals of the research. Reilly has also needed to remain open to research practices, even when he initially skeptical—such as during discussions around standardizing intake to promote equity and consistency.

A big part of this process has involved learning to speak each other's language. Academic terms like *logic model* or *standardization* often did not translate, just as Reilly's informal or cultural references sometimes required interpretation. These conversations built shared understanding and ensured that research tools were aligned with the program's values and accessible to staff and participants. Rather than seeing our differences as barriers, we treat them

as learning opportunities. This has helped us build mutual respect, which is especially vital in reentry work, where lived experience often offers insights uncaptured in peer-reviewed literature.

3 – Build Trust Through Shared Ownership

Never Give Up Transitional Living operates with a culture of "we," emphasizing that successful reentry and continued sobriety requires collective commitment and support. This ethos has extended into our RPP. From the start, it was essential that Reilly, as a practitioner with lived experience, felt genuine ownership over the partnership. His early request to include Gonzales signaled that this was not just about finding experts to run data or write grants—it was about working with people he trusted, people who cared as much as he did about the success of the men in the program. Indeed, strong partnerships rely not just on shared goals, but on mutual trust and respect. Therefore, from the outset we focused on learning *who* we were working with, not just *what* we were working on. Did we share a vision for better outcomes after prison? Could we be honest when things got hard? These early conversations helped determine whether this collaboration would be rooted in alignment or conflict. Thankfully, it has been the former.

Co-Creation in Action

Co-creation is about working side-by-side to shape the program to reflect both research goals and real-world needs. Therefore, the second pillar focuses on the "how" of collaboration.

4 – Clarify Roles and Boundaries Early and Often

Successful co-creation depends on a clear understanding of who is doing what. From the outset, we established a clear division between research and program implementation. Gonzales and Tostlebe support, advise, and contribute research-informed tools, while Reilly remains the heart of the program—retaining full authority over NGU's day-to-day operations and final decisions. This boundary protects the program's autonomy and integrity of future evaluation.

While we have roles, we do operate as a team, each contributing to knowledge generation and decision-making.[8] Reilly identifies real-time needs and Gonzales and Tostlebe help assess options and develop materials. Occasionally, he has wanted them to speak to the program's effectiveness; these moments have sparked valuable conversations about objectivity and the need for evaluation before making claims. Gonzales and Tostlebe, in turn, depend on Reilly's insight into program operations: what is working, what is not, and what is needed. In co-developing tools or documents, Gonzales and Tostlebe typically draft materials and then collaborate with Reilly to adjust based on practical realities. For complex or sensitive topics, we schedule sit-down conversations to align research-informed ideas with staff capabilities or participant needs. For example, when Reilly found an early participant tracking tool overwhelming, we met as a team to walk through it together—an illustration of how co-creation requires flexibility and feedback. This illustrates the heart of our RPP: a constant process of listening, testing, revising, and aligning roles based on each new task.

5 – Start Slow and Build with Flexibility

Early in the partnership, NGU operated on a highly individualized model shaped by Reilly's lived experience. Akin to the experiences of Lane et al. (2004), Reilly preferred a case-by-case approach where program components like intake, removal, and progression varied on a case-by-case basis. This approach allowed the program to respond flexibly to each participant's unique needs. However, this design also makes evaluation and potential replication challenging. Gonzales and Tostlebe, while equally committed to honoring individual needs, approached the program from a research perspective, emphasizing the importance of standardization to support evaluation, long-term sustainability, and, if successful, future replication.

[8] Drawing on Sjölund et al.'s (2023) role typology, we most often operate as co-inquiries and design advisors (R)/design validators (P), with moments of facilitation.

Bridging these perspectives has been a slow process—and we are still in the trenches. Early on, Tostlebe proposed a rigorous evaluation design, but the timing was too early. Reilly pushed back, and after some discussion, they agreed to revisit the evaluation design later when the program and partnership were more established (see Lesson 9 for a fuller discussion of evaluation and ethical tensions). We have had similar experiences around smaller components. Over time, we have worked together to combine lived expertise with a research-informed structure. As our RPP has evolved, tools have become more structured and formalized—but always through dialogue, collaborative revisions, and a shared commitment to NGU. And Reilly has realized that standardization is not about giving up control but rather ensuring sustainability. The lesson: start small, listen more than you talk, and move at a pace the partnership can sustain.

6 – Co-Creation Requires Negotiation (and Sometimes Conflict)

Disagreement is not a sign of failure; it is often a sign that people are fully engaged. We have encountered numerous tensions. But some of our best tools have emerged through friction. Differing perspectives pushed us to think more critically to align materials to fit the needs of NGU. For example, Gonzales and Tostlebe revised the Dialectical Behavior Therapy curriculum. But some of the standard exercises did not resonate with the program's population, so the curriculum was adjusted to focus on lessons that felt relevant and accessible. The result was not a loss of evidence-based content, but a tailored version grounded in lived realities. Overall, the key has been staying at the table and trusting that disagreement can lead to stronger outcomes.

7 – Documentation is Infrastructure

One of the most important forms of collaborative creation we have engaged in is writing things down. Reilly has been a critical source of knowledge. At the same time, he is the first to admit he is not always the *most* organized human. By working together, we have transformed his

expertise into formal, evidence-based tools, which have strengthened NGU's infrastructure by smoothing intake, clarifying expectations, and supporting consistent decision-making. Therefore, while documentation is often seen as a research task, we have also found it essential for practice. Standardizing procedures, programming guides, and case management templates supports future evaluation efforts *and* empowers staff, increases transparency, helps participants know what to expect, and communicates the inner workings of the program to funders and community partners. Documentation does not replace lived experience; it preserves and elevates it.

Embrace Real-World Complexity

A reentry program is anything but a controlled, scientific laboratory. It is fluid, unpredictable, and often messy—reflecting the real process of reentry. This pillar is about adapting to complexity without compromising the goals of the RPP.

8 – Flexibility is Essential

As Petersilia (2008) observed, the culture of academia is "one of autonomy, academic freedom, and professional civility" (p. 352). Furthermore, she highlighted how academics tend to be self-paced, often moving slowly. While these characteristics fit scholarly work, they do not always translate into the fast-moving, unpredictable realities of reentry.

Flexibility has flowed both ways in our RPP. Reilly favors a case-by-case approach over formalized procedures; he was used to making decisions quickly and intuitively. Gonzales and Tostlebe, alternatively, move more deliberately—defining terms and piloting tools before implementing major changes. Navigating this difference required ongoing negotiation and open communication. For example, when the original program collapsed (at least in terms of Reilly's involvement), a new version launched almost overnight. Within days, Reilly asked Gonzales and Tostlebe to help develop foundational materials: a program description, participant application,

rules and expectations, and employee role descriptions. Gonzales and Tostlebe shifted their academic schedules and quickly met at a coffee shop to draft working versions based on best practices and Reilly's notes and guidance. These documents were quickly revised, circulated, and adopted—providing the structure needed to launch the new program. However, adaptability did not mean compromising rigor. It meant Reilly needed to slow down and consult with others, while Gonzales and Tostlebe needed to be ready to roll up their sleeves in a moment's notice to help the real world (Petersilia, 2008). Flexibility allows partnerships to survive instability and barriers, which can arrive any time, in any setting (Hodgkinson et al., 2024).

9 – Balance Scientific Rigor with Ethical Realities

RPPs often operate in the space between academic ideals and real-world constraints. Rigorous evaluation designs—like randomized controlled trials (RCTs)—can generate strong evidence (Deaton & Cartwright, 2018; Weisburd, 2000). However, they have their own set of limitations (Nagin & Sampson, 2019; Weisburd, 2010) and do not always align with the ethical commitments or practical needs of community-based programs (see Fox, 2017).

We have encountered this tension firsthand. Early on, Tostlebe floated the idea of conducting an RCT—not as an immediate next step, but to plant the seed for future evaluation. However, the idea of randomly deciding who would receive services—and who would not—felt troubling to Reilly. He was uncomfortable with the idea of preventing someone from paroling due to being denied access to NGU or refusing support to someone returning to the community. The conversation did not escalate, but it also did not advance. That moment revealed a truth of RPPs: what is methodologically rigorous may not always be ethically or practically appropriate.

These debates are not easy to resolve, and they have sparked a broader, ongoing dialogue about how to design an evaluation strategy that procedures credible evidence without

compromising the program's mission. Our stance is that the best evaluation design is one that reflects the ethical commitments of the program *and* the standards of academic research—but whether that balance is achievable through RCT, propensity score matching, or another method is still an open question. But the process of negotiating that balance must be part of the work.

Keep the Mission Centered

The final pillar is a reminder of what matters most: the men reentering society. They are not data points or test cases. They are people, and they are the reason this partnership exists.

10 – Center the People Most Affected

From the beginning, we have built research-based tools and structures to reflect the lived realities of the men navigating the challenges of reentry. Participants are not passive recipients of services—they are central stakeholders in both the program and the research. As Maruna (2025) reminds us, lived experience is not just personal testimony—it is a form of expert knowledge that can reshape the very systems that failed them. Having a practitioner partner with lived experience has been one of the most meaningful and thought-provoking aspects of this work. Gonzales and Tostlebe are honored to be in an RPP and writing this chapter with Reilly.

We have also prioritized transparency and respect. Participants know who we are and why we are present. We do not conduct interviews, but we observe the program as permitted by our current IRB. We only use images or materials with informed consent. These small practices reflect our broader commitment to building trust and respecting the boundaries of our roles in the house. Centering the people most affected by incarceration and reentry is a daily commitment.

Concluding Thoughts: Looking Toward the Future

What began as a shared desire to understand, document, and strengthen a functioning transitional living program has evolved into a collaborative effort to build a new sustainable

program grounded in both lived experience and evidence-based practice. From the beginning we have maintained distinct roles: Gonzales and Tostlebe provide guidance rooted in empirical research and evaluation expertise, while Reilly leads implementation and brings deep knowledge of lived experience and the practical realities of what is feasible. While many challenges remain, the foundation we have built together positions us to successfully meet them head-on.

This work is unfolding within a broader national context in which prison overcrowding, decarceration, and reentry are increasingly recognized as critical concerns within the criminal justice system. In Nebraska, recent news headlines have spotlighted these concerns:

> *'Asking for trouble': Nebraska's bulging prisons and double bunking impasse*
> – Shelby Rickert, Nebraska Public Media, June 9, 2025
>
> *Supreme Court upholds Legislature's authority to expand parole eligibility*
> – Zach Wendling, Nebraska Examiner, April 18, 2025
>
> *Sentencing reform task force recommends deep dive into improving success of inmates after release*
> – Paul Hammel, Nebraska Examiner, November 29, 2024

Transitional living programs—like NGU—offer a promising path forward, but knowledge of their effectiveness is limited by inconsistent program implementation, limited resources, and lack of formal assessment. While our partnership alone cannot fill that gap, it does demonstrate what is possible—the promises and tensions—when academics and practitioners come together.

Moving forward, our focus remains on collaboratively creating tools that reflect both empirical rigor and lived experience, as well as developing an agreed-upon strategy for formal evaluation and refining the program based on results. We are committed to building a transitional living program model that supports the success of individuals returning to the community from prison, and contributes to broader conversations about what effective, holistic, human-centered programming can look like. In that, one core principle endures: NEVER GIVE UP.

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Tables and Figures

Table 1. Transitional housing facilities

	HALFWAY HOUSE	OXFORD HOUSE	RESIDENTIAL REENTRY CENTER (RRCS)	TRANSITIONAL LIVING PROGRAM
Definition	Structured housing for justice-involved or recovering individuals	Peer-run sober living home focused on recovery	Federally contracted reentry facility for federal prisoners	Supportive, time-limited housing for community reintegration
Primary Population	Parolees, probationers, individuals exiting jail or treatment	Individuals in recovery from substance use disorders	Federal prisoners nearing sentence completion	Individuals exiting prison
Eligibility Criteria	Varies by agency or referral source	Individuals committed to sober living	Federal prisoners approved by Bureau of Prisons	Varies: criminal history, housing need, recovery status
Oversight	State agencies, nonprofits, private funders	Peer governed, self-managed by residents	Federal Bureau of Prisons contracts with providers	Nonprofits, community organizations
Funding Source	State contracts, grants, private pay	Resident rent payments, grants	Federal	Grants, donations, state contracts
Length of Stay	Variable; often 3-12 months	No fixed limit; varies by recovery progress	Variable: often 6-12 months	Variable: often 60-180 days
Level of Supervision	Moderate to high	Low; peer accountability	High	Moderate to high
Housing Type	Shared living	Shared house	Shared facility	Shared or individual rooms
Required Programming	Required: often includes employment, treatment, life skills	No formal programming	Required: employment, drug testing, counseling	Required: employment, case management, life skills, therapy, support services
Curfews / Rules	Yes—moderate to strict	Yes—house rules and group accountability	Yes—strict	Yes—strict

Note. Other distinguishing features exist; theses were selected as they are most critical to the Never Give Up Transitional Living program discussed in this chapter.

Table 2. Transitional living housing programs in the United States

PROGRAM	CREATION YEAR	LENGTH OF PROGRAM	PROGRAM COMPONENTS	EVALUATION RESULTS
Alpha House Springfield, MO (thealphahouse.org)	1972	--	- Case management - Employment assistance - Financial classes - Mental health counseling - Substance abuse counseling	- N/A
Bristol Station Residential Reentry Program Hastings, NE (wacinc.net/bristol-station)	2008	--	- Case management - Employment assistance - Financial classes - Moral Reconation Therapy (MRT) - Sober living	- N/A
Dimas House Nashville, TN (dismas.org)	1974	90 days min., no max.	- Case management - Employment assistance - Financial classes - Interpersonal skills development - Legal support - Relapse planning	- N/A
Exodus Transitional Community Poughkeepsie, NY (etcny.org)	2014	--	- Case management - Employment assistance - Peer support	- N/A
Golden Rule Reentry Medford, OR (goldenrulereentry.org)	2020	--	- Case management - Employment assistance - Peer support - Professional skills classes - Prosocial events - Sober living	- N/A
Justice 4 Housing Boston, MA (justice4housing.org)	--	182-365 days	- Case management - Employment assistance - Financial classes - Housing placement - Substance abuse counseling	- N/A

(continued)

PROGRAM	CREATION YEAR	LENGTH OF PROGRAM	- PROGRAM COMPONENTS	- EVALUATION RESULTS
Never Give Up Transitional Living Omaha, NE (nevergiveupomaha.org)	2025	84 days	- Alcoholics and narcotics anonymous - Community engagement - Dialectical Behavior Therapy (DBT) - Employment assistance - Essential documents assistance - Family engagement - Faith-based support - Financial classes - Individual counseling - Intensive Outpatient Treatment (IOP) - Peer support - Prosocial events - Sober living	- N/A
Phoenix Oasis Reentry Services Phoenix, AZ (phxoasis.com)	--	90 days	- Case management - Counseling and behavioral therapies - Employment assistance - Intensive Outpatient Treatment (IOP)	- N/A
Ridge House Reno, NV (ridgehouse.org)	1982	--	- Case management - Counseling and behavioral therapies - Credit restoration - Employment assistance - Sober living	- Quasi-experimental design (Willison et al., 2010) - Participants had 0.12 fewer arrests for society crimes than comparison group - Program completers had a 16% lower probability of being rearrested than the comparison group

(continued)

PROGRAM	CREATION YEAR	LENGTH OF PROGRAM	- PROGRAM COMPONENTS	- EVALUATION RESULTS
Riverside House Miami, FL (riversidehouse.org)	1973	Individualized	- Group and individual counseling - Employment assistance - Prosocial events - Release planning - Sober living	- N/A
Sponsors Inc. Lane County, OR (sponsorsinc.org)	1973	60-120 days	- Behavioral health services - Case management - Employment assistance - Peer support - Sober living	- N/A
Talbert House Ohio counties (talberthouse.org)	1965	180 days max.	- Education services - Employment assistance - Individualized treatment plan - Sober living	- N/A
Turning Point of Central California Salinas, CA (tpocc.org)	1970	180 days max.	- Case management - Education services - Employment assistance - Mental health treatment - Substance abuse counseling	- N/A
Volunteer of America Correctional Services United States (voa.org)	1896	--	- Case management - Literacy training - Substance abuse counseling	- N/A

Notes. Information derived from program websites in July 2025; some information was unavailable. Search process is documented in chapter.